THE HALCYON CYCLE



The Halcyon Cycle — Series Bible

author's reference · complete

[AUTHOR NAME]

CONTAINS SPOILERS FOR THE ENTIRE SERIES. Author-facing reference.

THE HALCYON CYCLE — Seven-Book Architecture

Series title: *The Halcyon Cycle* Saga question: What is the Hollow Sea, and what do we owe what we have kept? Saga truth (fixed): The sea was *kept*, with a people inside it, by the Halcyon's founders, to win a war. All grain-work spends that people's held moment. The ending is restitution: the slow return of the sea, the end of salt magic as known, the reunion of two peoples, and Hester's return of her brother. Thematic spine: Keeping versus loving. Preservation versus restitution. What we owe the past. Conflict progression: each book changes the kind of conflict.

#	Title	Kind of conflict	Season / year
1	What the Salt Keeps	Mystery (who / why), personal	Autumn–Midwinter 903
2	The Lantern Tithe	Political-institutional intrigue	Spring–Midsummer 904
3	A Map of Still Water	Expedition and exploration	Autumn 904–Spring 905
4	The Drowned Choir	First contact; moral crisis	905–906
5	The Red Grain	Civil conflict; war	906–907
6	The Ebb Reversed	Engineering catastrophe and recovery	907–908
7	When the Sea Remembers	Restitution; reckoning	908–909

BOOK 1 — WHAT THE SALT KEEPS

[A]Theme: Holding on is not the same as loving.

[A]Central conflict: The charity sleepers' casings are weeping, and the Reader who noticed is "dead." Hester must find out why before her brother's casing fails.

[A]Setting developments: The Halcyon introduced; Ambry; the Cistern; the Stays; the Hush; the first open water on the White in 900 years.

[A]Arcs:

Hester: control $_{q}$ stewardship.

Teo: flight $_{q}$ listening.

Saskia: self $_{q}$ loyalty.

Lucan: son $_{q}$ self.

Sorle: bitterness $_{q}$ purpose.

Orsolya: protector $_{q}$ criminal $_{q}$ redeemed in a single act.

[A]Discoveries: Still runs to quick (applied); venting; quickened grain is living sea.

[A]Political: the Ferrers–Warden contract scandal; Orsolya arrested; Exchequer embarrassed; the Seal shaken.

[A]Mystery: the draw; Aske's "death."

[A]Revelations:

The stays are fed by the sleepers.

Orsolya.

Aske is alive.

A living gull.

A voice in the salt.

[A]Climax: cutting the draw and venting the Hush quickening up the Founders' Shaft.

[A]Resolution: The sleepers are safe. Aske is returned. Hester is sponsored by Sorle and has passed her Assay. She tells Tib the truth.

[A]Saga consequences: A salt lake on the White ("the Tear"). A living gull. A word: *Aelith*.

BOOK 2 — THE LANTERN TITHE

[A]Premise: The new water on the White is a sensation. The Exchequer moves to tax and mine it; the Tiders proclaim the Return; Quell sends envoys. The Halcyon convenes a Board of Inquiry into the "Shelf Event," with Hester (newly second-year) as its Lowside appointee. The Conclave also proposes a Lantern Tithe, a tax on kept light to fund new Stays, which falls hardest on Quell glaziers and Lowside lantern-carriers.

[A]Themes: Who owns the truth? The cost of light.

[A]Acts:

1. Inquiry politics. Aske recovering. Dunmore's flight traced.
2. Saskia drawn into Quell–Lumen intrigue (kept light hoarded by Vey's agents to manipulate the Tithe vote). Lantern sabotage.
3. The Founders' Gallery: Hester, Callow and Aske find the Seal's ledger fragment.
4. Midsummer Lantern Harvest: the public exposure of the Seal's existence.

[A]Central conflict: Hester and the reformers against Vey and the Seal over whether the inquiry may examine the founding.

[A]Arcs:

Hester learns power is not truth.

Saskia chooses between the Lodge's money and the Halcyon.

Lucan works inside his father's house.

Aske relearns his hands.

[A]Discoveries: the Seal; Ysolde's partial journal ("the Keeping was the only mercy left us"). The Held Moment proven by Sorle and Hester's measurement of the Tear's salt crust re-forming *from the past* (the new crust reads as 0 Y.E.).

[A]Mystery: who is buying kept light? (Vey, to swing the Tithe and fund a secret Hush stay project.)

[A]Climax: Lantern Harvest Night. The sabotaged lantern-presses nearly burn the Rookery; Saskia's annealing saves the presses; Callow's testimony is entered.

[A]Resolution: Chancellor Holm resigns and confesses that the founders "made the Ebb" (to end a flood, she claims). Sorle is vindicated. Vey becomes Chancellor by vote, a bitter turn. The Tithe fails.

[A]Consequences: The public now knows the Ebb was made. They do not yet know *how*, or that people are in it.

BOOK 3 — A MAP OF STILL WATER

[A]Premise: To test the Held Moment, a Halcyon–Lodge joint expedition crosses the White to the Deep by landship, led by Aske with Hester as second. The Wend salt-walkers guide them. The goal is to sound the Deep and find "Ilisse" if it exists.

[A]Themes: Maps and territory; belief and evidence.

[A]Acts:

1. Departure. The landship convoy. Whiteouts.
2. The Wend and their songs. Teo learns the Wend chant.
3. Mutiny and an Exchequer spy aboard. The sink-field.
4. The Deep: clear salt; the bell-tower of Ilisse seen 60 fathoms down.

[A]Central conflict: survival on the White, and the expedition split between Lodge openness and Exchequer secrecy.

[A]Arcs:

Hester and Lucan's romance begins.

Teo commits to listening.

Aske takes command and is wounded.

Saskia stays in Ambry and holds the Inquiry together, a parallel plot via letters.

[A]Discoveries:

A drowned city under the salt.

Bells in the Roar.

The Wend's oral tradition of "the people under the white sheet."

[A]Mystery: What is down there? Was Ilisse real? (Yes.)

[A]Climax: a sink-collapse in the Deep. Hester keeps the landship mid-plunge, a monumental hold, and lags for an hour; the crew vents her down. Through the clear salt they see the tower and *a figure at a window*.

[A]Resolution: the expedition returns with readings and a drawn map of the tower.

[A]Consequences: The Rim learns there is a city in the salt. Vey seals the Deep.

BOOK 4 — THE DROWNED CHOIR

[A]Premise: Teo, reading Deep grain, isolates speech in the Roar: a language. Hester realises that kept minds are not absolutely still at the casing boundary. Ostrin perception crawls: 900 years equals some minutes for them. The Ostrin *are alive and aware, mid-battle*. Every dram of grain ever dissolved has spent a sliver of their moment.

[A]Themes: Complicity; whether you can apologise across time.

[A]Acts:

1. The Listening. Teo builds a lexicon, aided by the Wend songs.
2. The ethics explode publicly. The Tiders riot; the Exchequer suppresses.
3. The "Choir" project: the Stay Choir is repurposed to *sing* into the salt, to communicate.
4. Contact.

[A]Central conflict: whether to halt deep mining (economic collapse) or continue (consuming a people).

[A]Arcs:

Hester's crisis: her whole craft has been spending people.

Aldous dies, after visiting Tib at last.

Lucan and Hester become lovers.

Teo becomes the Listener.

[A]Discoveries: the Ostrin language; the Ostrin invented keeping. The Marrane stole it.

[A]Mystery: what are they saying? "*Aelith?*" means "Is it over?" They believe the battle is still raging.

[A]Climax: Teo and Hester answer through the Choir. A reply comes, a name: *Vaimé* (an Ostrin keeper-priestess).

[A]Resolution: the Conclave votes to halt deep mining. The Exchequer's economy cracks. Riots.

[A]Consequences: the road to war.

BOOK 5 — THE RED GRAIN

[A]Premise: Aurel Ferrers and Chancellor Vey's Charterists ally with Hask mercenaries to seize the Shelf and resume mining. Sanguine Grain is used as a weapon: keyed keepings of hostages.

[A]Themes: Order versus justice. Who pays.

[A]Acts:

1. The Exchequer coup.
2. Lowside rising with the Delvers.
3. The siege of the Halcyon.
4. Ysolde's full journal discovered.

[A]Central conflict: civil war on the Rim.

[A]Arcs:

Lucan breaks with his father publicly.

Orsolya is released into service.

Saskia's Pip is taken hostage in a keyed keeping, and freed by Hester using sanguine knowledge, a moral stain.

Sorle dies Settled, giving his last lecture to the Choir.

[A]Discoveries: the founders knowingly kept 200,000 people to annihilate the Ilisse fleet. Ysolde's last line: "We will tell them it was the sea's doing. God forgive us, we will believe it ourselves."

[A]Climax: the Battle of the Causeway. Vey falls (arrested). Ferrers flees.

[A]Resolution: the Rim Concord Treaty of Harl establishes a *Commission of Return*. Lowside is half-burned.

[A]Consequences: the decision to return the sea.

BOOK 6 — THE EBB REVERSED

[A]Premise: Returning a sea instantly would flood the Rim cities built on the old seabed, and its arrears would be catastrophic. The Commission plans the Great Vent: a years-long staged return through a ring of shafts, with evacuation of the lower cities. First returns happen at the margins. Returned Ostrin arrive mid-battle, terrified.

[A]Themes: Repair is harder than harm; living with the wronged.

[A]Acts:

1. Engineering and evacuation.
2. The first returned: an Ostrin girl, Thaelin; violence; fear.
3. Ostrin keeper-craft. Vaimé returned; an alliance.
4. Sabotage: a vent gate fails.

[A]Central conflict: sabotage by remnant Charterists, and Rim fear of the Ostrin.

[A]Arcs:

Orsolya dies holding the failing gate.

Teo is heavily Settled.

Hester fails publicly: a vent she designed floods lower Ambry. She recovers.

Saskia becomes the Commission's head.

[A]Discoveries: Ostrin medicine. The bloom fever was an Ostrin-known disease, "the sea-cough," and its cure exists in kept Ilisse physic-houses.

[A]Climax: the Gate of Coldbank holds through Orsolya's last hold.

[A]Resolution: Ostrin and Rim workers together stabilise the Vent.

[A]Consequences: the final Return is possible.

BOOK 7 — WHEN THE SEA REMEMBERS

[A]Premise: The final Return: Ilisse itself, and the heart of the moment. Stillsalt across the Rim weakens as the moment is spent. Every keeping in the world will fail within a year, so every family with a sleeper must choose.

[A]Themes: Letting go; what is kept *can* be returned.

[A]Acts:

1. The world's keepings weakening; the Brineries' great choice.
2. Hester's descent to Ilisse's physic-house.
3. The Return of Ilisse: the sea coming home over a season.
4. Tib.

[A]Central conflict: the last Charterist (Ferrers) attempts to keep a last vast reserve of grain, a "Second Keeping." Hester must choose to release it all.

[A]Arcs: Hester's completion: she returns Tib with the Ostrin cure, knowing he will wake into loss. Lucan and Hester. Teo speaks the Return.

[A]Resolution:

The sea returns to the Hollow over a season.

The halcyon birds fly from the returning water.

The Halcyon is refounded as a sea-university, its lower Fathoms flooded by consent.

Magic dims: stillsalt keeps no longer, and only the memory of the art remains.

Final image: Hester and Tib on the deck of a boat on a real sea, Tib whistling.

[A]Final outcomes:

Hester: Reader of the new Halcyon; partner to Lucan.

Tib: pilot.

Teo: Listener and interpreter, living with partial Settle.

Saskia: Chancellor.

Lucan: Rim Concord delegate.

Aske: grower of oysters, happily.

Vaimé: Ostrin Speaker.

25+ Signature Moments (saga)

1. (B1) Hester visiting a brother who has been fourteen for eleven years.
2. (B1) The First Taste: a hall of adults weeping salt tears at the Long Table.
3. (B1) Hearing the sea for the first time in the Stay Choir.
4. (B1) Keeping Lucan mid-fall into a sink, then lagging.
5. (B1) Lantern Night: a summer's light poured out over a winter city.
6. (B1) The Cistern: brass draw-rods in founders' tunnels.
7. (B1) Orsolya's offer: "I can route it round him."
8. (B1) The sea rising up the Founders' Shaft into the winter night.
9. (B1) A gull, alive, the first in 900 years.
10. (B1) Hester telling Tib the truth.
11. (B1) Aske waking mid-sentence after three months.
12. (B2) The new crust that reads as Year 0.
13. (B2) Holm's confession: "We made the Ebb."
14. (B2) Vey elected Chancellor: a devastating reversal.
15. (B3) The Wend singing to the salt at night.
16. (B3) Seeing a bell-tower through 60 fathoms of clear salt.
17. (B3) Hester keeping a whole landship.

18. (B4) Teo isolating the first word.
19. (B4) Aldous at Tib's casing after nine years.
20. (B4) "Aelith?" translated: "Is it over?"
21. (B4) The Choir singing *into* the salt and receiving a name.
22. (B5) Sorle's last lecture.
23. (B5) Ysolde's journal: "we will believe it ourselves."
24. (B5) Hester freeing Pip with forbidden grain.
25. (B6) The first returned Ostrin, a girl with a sword, mid-battle in a desert.
26. (B6) Orsolya's final hold.
27. (B6) Hester's vent failing and Lowside flooding.
28. (B7) Every Brinery's choice: a city returning its sleepers.
29. (B7) Tib waking, cured, and asking, "Hes? Why are you old?"
30. (B7) Halcyon birds over the returned sea.

WORLD BIBLE — The Rim and the Hollow Sea

Internal author reference. Sections marked [SPOILER] contain objective truths not yet revealed to readers.

1. Geography

The Hollow Sea ("the White"). - An elongated basin roughly 300 miles east–west and 120 miles north–south, floored by a salt crust. - The crust runs from a few feet thick at the margins (the Shelf) to an unknown depth in the centre (the Deep). Deep borings have reached 900 fathoms without finding rock. - Its surface is white, glazed and polygonally cracked into plates ("tiles") a few yards across. - Hazards: - sinks: soft brine pockets under crust, which swallow carts and people; - whiteouts: salt storms; - glare-blindness; - the Pull: a mirage effect that makes distances lie. - Brine pools at the margins are tinted rose-red and copper-green by halophile algae and brine shrimp ("pinkwater", "greenwater"). - At night, in the dry season, the White sings: thermal contraction makes the plates tick and chime.

The Rim (the habitable band around the White): - Western Rim. - Ambry (pop. ~180,000), the largest free city. It is built on the old western shore, and its lower districts sit on the former seabed. - The Halcyon stands 2 miles east of Ambry on a salt dome called the Shelf (also "the Knoll"), joined to the city by the raised Causeway. - The river Ambrel once fed the sea; it now ends in brackish marshes north of the city called the Weeps. - Northern Rim. The Varrow Range: snow mountains, rock-salt mines (dead salt) and the mountain kingdom of Hask, a buyer of kept medicine. The town of Ostmere sits at the passes. - Eastern Rim. Quell (pop. ~70,000), the glass city. It is home of the Quell Lodge, a rival academy founded in the Schism of 512 Y.E. that is more open, poorer and more radical. Quell glass is the best in the world. - Southern Rim. Harl and the Mar-

dens: farmland on dried river deltas, and the seat of the Order of the Returning Tide's mother house, Tidewater Abbey. Beyond them lies the red desert called the Scald. - The Deep. Uninhabited. Salt-walkers (the Wend) cross it on seasonal routes and sing to the salt. [SPOILER: the drowned island-city of Ilisse is held beneath the Deep. Its tallest bell-tower lies only ~60 fathoms below the surface, visible through clear deep salt in certain seasons (Book 3).]

Climate. - Continental: hot dry summers, cold clear winters with hard frosts. - Autumn rains on the Rim are brief. The White itself almost never rains. - Winds: the Sere, a dry east wind in autumn that carries salt dust into Ambry.

2. History (public, with [SPOILER] truths)

Calendar: Years of the Ebb (Y.E.). Book One opens on 1 Russet 903 Y.E.

[A]Before the Ebb.

Public: the Ostrine Sea, an inland sea, rich in fish. The Marrane coastal kingdoms traded on it. The island cities of the Ostrin were a sea-people with their own language; little is known of them, "lost with the sea."

[SPOILER] The Ostrin of Ilisse were a thalassocracy and the originators of salt-keeping. They kept fish, medicine, and their honoured dead. The Marrane fought a twenty-year war against them (c. 20 B.E.–0) and were losing.

[A]0 Y.E., the Ebb.

Public: in one night the sea withdrew, leaving salt. Most coastal people survived because the water *went*, not came. The Order of the Returning Tide teaches that the sea withdrew in judgement and will return when the Rim is worthy.

[SPOILER] A Marrane society of salt-workers, the Quiet Company, led by Ysolde Marrane and Corrant Hask, used stolen Ostrin craft and an enormous synchronised hold of some three thousand workers (most of whom died Settled) to perform the Great Keeping. It stilled the entire sea in a single instant, with

the Ilisse fleet on it, the island cities in it, and some 200,000 Ostrin.

A3 Y.E. The Quiet Company founds the Halcyon on the Shelf "to study the gift of the Ebb." Ysolde is First Reader. Its motto: *What is kept is not lost.* [SPOILER: its true founding purpose was to guard the Keeping and its secret. The inner circle is called the Seal.]

Ac. 40–90 Y.E. The first Brineries. Grain-work spreads.

A140 Y.E. The Charter of the Grain, granted by the Rim League. The Halcyon gains the monopoly on licensing grain-work.

A212 Y.E. The Salt Exchequer is founded in Ambry to tax grain.

A****[SPOILER]** 230 Y.E.** The Seal destroys most surviving pre-Ebb records. This is publicly remembered as "the Brinestacks Fire."

A341–349 Y.E. The Delving Wars: a labour revolt of the miners. They end with the Delvers' Guild Accord.

A512 Y.E. The Quell Schism: a third of the Readers, led by Aster Quell, leave over secrecy to found the Lodge at Quell.

A611 Y.E. The Red Grain murders. A Reader, Mattias Horne, used human-salt keyings to make unopenable keepings of his victims. Sanguine Grain is banned.

A788 Y.E. The Great Bloom: a lung-fever epidemic. The Brineries overflow, and the Cold House opens as a charity brinery.

A871 Y.E. "Sorle's Folly": Reader Benedek Sorle presents the Held Moment Hypothesis to the Conclave. He is demolished in debate, chiefly by a young Fathomer named Orsolya Thane, and censured.

A892 Y.E. Tobias Vail, 14, is kept at the Cold House with bloom fever.

A896–903 Y.E. Quickenings in the Halcyon's Fifth Fathom increase about threefold. This is publicly unknown.

A902 Y.E. Orsolya Thane, Warden of the Lower Fathoms, reopens the founders' Cistern lines and begins drawing stillness from the Cold House's charity keepings.

A903 Y.E. Book One.

3. Politics and law

[A]Ambry: a free city governed by the Assize, a council of 31 guild and ward representatives, with a Lord Mayor chosen annually. The real power sits with three bodies:

1. The Halcyon. Holds the Charter. Licenses all grain-work and certifies grades. Its Proctors police grain crime.
2. The Salt Exchequer. A civic-mercantile body that taxes and trades grain and holds export licences. It is led by the Lord Exchequer, Aurel Ferrers (Lucan's father).
3. The Delvers' Guild. The miners' union. It controls labour and can halt supply.

[A]The Rim Concord: a loose treaty league of Rim cities (Ambry, Quell, Harl, Ostmere) for trade and mutual defence, with a weak Concord Diet.

[A]Law (Charter offences):

unlicensed keeping;
sale of Hush grain (felony);
falsified grading (fraud);
Sanguine Grain (capital);
improper return of a kept person (homicide).

[A]Courts: the Assize Court for city matters; the Proctory Court within the Halcyon for grain offences by its members.

[A]Kept-person law. A kept person is legally alive while their casing is clear. Next of kin may sign keeping and release. The Stillborn clause treats a person kept beyond return as legally dead: their estate passes and their casing becomes property of the brinery or the Halcyon.

4. Economy

[A]Currency: the sol (silver), divided into 20 flecks (copper). A gold crown is worth 25 sols and is rarely seen in Lowside.

[A]Wages and prices:

Hester's customs wage: 14 sols/month.

A dock labourer: about 7 sols.

The Cold House charity keeping fee: 6 sols/month.

A private brinery: 30+ sols/month.

Halcyon fees: 120 sols/year.

[A]Grain prices: Shelf, 2 flecks/dram; Middling, 1 sol/ounce; Deep, 12 sols/ounce; Hush grain is never legally sold, and its black-market price is about 100 sols/ounce.

[A]Main trades:

grain and kept goods;

kept light;

Quell glass;

Harl grain, meaning wheat (a constant pun: "Harl grain or Halcyon grain?");

Hask timber and furs;

brine-boiling, which produces dead salt for ordinary table use from Weeps marsh-brine;

landship-building.

5. Transport

[A]Landships ("salt-yachts"): wind-driven sledges on iron runners that sail the White. They range from two-person skiffs to great three-masted freighters, and they are fast, often 20+ knots in a good wind. Ambry's old harbour is now a dry harbour: quays standing above salt where landships moor, sails furled, runners chocked.

[A]The Causeway: a raised stone-and-salt road, 2 miles from Ambry's Eastgate to the Halcyon Gatehouse, lit at night with kept-light posts.

[A]Ox-drays: for overland Rim trade.

[A]Brine-lifts: counterweight cages in the Halcyon, balanced by brine tanks.

[A][SPOILER] The Cistern: a network of founders'-era brine tunnels and pipes under Ambry. Officially the old municipal brine supply, bricked up in 400 Y.E. Its main line runs from the Great Cistern under Coldwater Street (now beneath the Cold House) east to the Halcyon's Fifth Fathom.

6. Cultures, peoples, naming

[A]Rim Marrane (Ambry, Western Rim). The majority. Names are Rim-English in flavour with Marrane survivals: Hester, Aldous, Tobias, Agathe, Corvin, Maudelaine, Halloran; surnames like Vail, Aske, Crisp, Pell, Fenn, Mallory, Gage, Callow, Ferrers.

> Lowside speech is clipped and practical, with "I'll not," "wants doing," "ta," "chick" (an endearment).
>
> Upper-ward speech is formal and Latinate.

[A]Quellish (Eastern Rim). Glassmakers; clipped, ironic, with a reputation for mercenariness and candour. Names: Saskia, Jory, Orme, Pip (Philippa), Aster.

[A]Harlish (Southern Rim). Farming and Tider country; slow, devout, hospitable. Names: Teodor (Teo), Anselm, Benedek (Sorle is of Harlish birth), Ama.

[A]Haskish (mountains). Names in -ik, -vo: Ivo, Radik.

[A]The Wend (salt-walkers). A nomad people of the White who hold the salt sacred and sing to it. They are reputed to hear the Roar better than anyone. Book 3.

[A]Ostrin (lost) [SPOILER]. Language fragments survive in place names, in "Ostrine," and in the Wend songs. Ostrin phonology: open vowels, -ae, -ille, -or, liquid consonants (Ilisse, Thaelor, Vaimé). The first Ostrin word heard in Book One's final chapter is "Aelith?", glossed in Book 4 as "Is it over?" / "Has it passed?"

[A]Orsolya Thane's family were Haskish-Lowside, which explains "Orsolya."

7. Religion and philosophy

[A]The Order of the Returning Tide ("Tiders").

Teaching: the sea withdrew in judgement and will return when the Rim is reconciled.

Practice: they oppose deep mining as wounding the sea's bed. Their holy night is the Ebbtide Vigil (end of Rime), when the faithful walk out onto the White with candles to "meet the tide." They keep the dead unkept: they refuse brining, believing the kept cannot meet the returning sea.

Organisation: abbeys, hospices and charity. Mother Agathe of the Cold House is a lay Tider; the house tolerates brining as "the people's choice."

[SPOILER: their prophecy is literally true, and their founding was by Marrane survivors who suspected the truth.]

[A]Civic Stillism. The secular Halcyon ethos: preservation as civilisation, the past as a resource. "What is kept is not lost."

[A]The Open Grain (Quell): knowledge should be shared, and the Charter is a tyranny.

[A]Common oaths: "Salt and sorrow." "Tide take it." "Still as a Reader." "Sweet sea" (mild, Lowside).

8. Daily life, food, art

[A]Food:

kept-fish: perch and eels from Hask lakes, sold kept;

salt-crust bread;

brine-pickles;

pinkwater shrimp paste;

Harl wheat porridge;

saltcake: a sweet caramel cake with crunchy grain-free salt flakes, a Halcyon student staple;

Hask honey;

bitter-orange from the Mardens;

"halcyon tea": black tea with a pinch of shelf salt and milk.

[A]Drink: small beer; Harl cider; "Quell clear" (a fierce spirit). Water is precious on the White.

[A]Art: salt sculpture (temporary, carved in the dry season); kept-sound recitals; Quell glass; Lantern Night light-painting; the Rim ballads (sea songs for a sea no one has seen).

[A]Architecture:

Ambry: rough grey stone and salt-glazed brick, with steep roofs against the occasional hail.

Halcyon: carved salt (smooth, translucent at edges, faintly pink in lamplight), lattice-grown arches and salt-glass windows.

[A]Clothing: wool year-round for grain-workers; the Halcyon gown is undyed grey wool with a coloured cord for Bench rank; customs officers wear blue.

9. Creatures and ecology

[A]Salt-larks: small white birds nesting on brine-pool margins.

[A]Pale herons: tall wading birds with pink crests that stand in pinkwater.

[A]Brine shrimp: blooming red in season.

[A]Lurchers: lean Rim hounds bred to sense sinks.

[A]Weep crabs: small green crabs of the brackish Weeps.

[A]Salt-flies: biting.

[A]Salt roses: crystal formations that "grow" in a single night after rare rains, a sign of luck.

[A]Night-chime: the singing of salt tiles at night.

[A]Gulls: none. Gulls do not exist in the Rim; they are known only from old paintings and ballads. [In Ch. 2 Hester hears a gull in a reading and does not recognise the sound; Teo identifies it from a hymn-book woodcut description in Ch. 9. In Ch. 25 a living gull flies out of the vented sea.]

10. Warfare and diplomacy

[A]There has been no major Rim war in 200 years.

[A]City watches; the Halcyon Proctors (about 80); Exchequer excisemen.

[A]Hask is a buyer of kept medicine and a source of mercenaries.

[A]Quell and Ambry are in permanent commercial rivalry; the Lodge is barred from the Charter.

[A]Book 5's civil war turns on Exchequer excisemen versus Delver militias versus a Halcyon split.

11. Technology

[A]Roughly a late eighteenth-century analogue. Printing presses; clocks and watches (Hask makers); canals in the Mardens; glass optics (Quell); early chemistry; no steam power. Hydraulics are used in the brine-lifts.

[A]Kept light reduces candle use among the wealthy.

[A]Firearms exist (matchlock-era, rare) but are not used in Book One.

12. Historical controversies (live debates in 903)

1. The Held Moment Hypothesis ("Sorle's Folly") versus the Mineral Theory.
2. Deep-mining quotas: Exchequer pressure to mine deeper versus Delver safety and Tider objection.

3. The fee economy and the charity brineries: Lowside agitation for a free keeping law.
4. The Quell Lodge's petition to break the Charter.
5. The Stillborn clause: lawyers dispute whether kept-beyond-return persons are dead.
6. The Brinestacks Fire of 230 Y.E.: was it an accident?

MAGIC SYSTEM SPECIFICATION — "Grain-work" (authoritative)

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0. Summary in one breath

Salt from the Hollow Sea ("stillsalt", "grain") can hold a thing still in time. - A trained worker dissolves grain into live brine, enters the hold (a deliberate bodily stillness), and lends that stillness to the brine. The brine crystallises around a target and keeps it: paused, unchanging, alive if it was alive. - Kept salt can be read, giving the impression of the kept moment, and returned: dissolved, so that the kept thing resumes exactly where it stopped. - Nothing kept is free. Every keeping accrues arrears, a pressure to resume that must be paid when released. - Workers pay with their own body-time.

1. Origins

[A]Public belief (Reader canon, Book 1): In the Ebb, nine centuries ago, the Ostrine Sea receded in one night. Its salt, "touched by the catastrophe," carries held stillness. Why it does is officially unknown and philosophically debated. The orthodox view is that stillness is a mineral property formed under unique pressure. The heterodox view, "Sorle's Folly," is that the salt is a held moment.

[A]Objective truth (SPOILER; Series Bible only): The sea was kept. In 0 Y.E. the Quiet Company performed the Great Keeping, stilling the Ostrine Sea, the fleet of Ilisse and the island cities in a single instant. The water was held in crystalline form, so the "salt" is the sea's moment made sol-

id. Stillsalt carries stillness because it *is* stillness: a fragment of one held instant. Mining and dissolving grain spends that instant; each dissolved dram is a sliver of the sea's moment allowed to pass. The art of keeping was Ostrin in origin (they kept fish, medicine, the dead). The Marrane stole it in war.

2. Fundamental laws (as taught in the Halcyon Primer)

1. Salt keeps. Live brine, worked in the hold, crystallises around a target and keeps it in its present state.
2. Salt remembers. Kept salt holds an impression of what it kept. In the hold, a worker in contact with it perceives that impression: images, sounds, sensations, temperature.
3. Salt returns. Kept salt dissolved by a worker in the *release* (the reversed hold) gives its moment back. The kept thing resumes from exactly where it paused.
4. What is kept is owed. (The Law of Arrears.) A keeping accrues pressure in proportion to the *mass* kept, the *duration*, and the *liveliness* of what is held. Living things accrue faster than stone; motion faster than rest. Arrears discharge on return as heat, sound, a pressure shock (the "snap"), and in great keepings as violent motion.
5. Still runs to quick. (Taught in Year One, Horology and Fathoming.) Stillness moves through *physically continuous live brine* from the stiller to the quicker, the way heat moves from hot to cold through metal. It does not jump gaps. No symbolic or sympathetic links exist. Dry salt, glass and air insulate.

Corollary taught by Sorle (Horology): Old keepings grow *stiller* over time; they saturate. Old human keepings are among the stillest things in the world. *Objective reason:* the casing draws on the held life inside it, and on the deep grain's own held moment.

3. Materials

[A]Stillsalt / grain. Hollow-Sea salt only. Salt from elsewhere (rock-salt from the Varrow, salt from evaporated foreign seawater) is dead salt and keeps nothing.

[A]Grades by depth (the Exchequer schedule):

Shelf (surface to ~3 fathoms; weak): food, curing, cheap keepings of hours to weeks.

Middling (~3–40 fathoms): trade keepings, records, ordinary kept light.

Deep (~40–300 fathoms; costly): medical keepings of people, long archival keepings, fine lumen.

Hush grain (below the Fifth Fathom; restricted, never sold): enormously still and enormously pressured. It keeps anything clear, almost instantly, but its arrears are monstrous. Its sale is a felony under the Charter.

[A]Quickened grain: grain from near a quickening.

Signatures: warmth to the touch; inclusions of liquid water inside crystals ("live beads"); readings carry vivid sea-sounds; it tastes *sweet-metallic and wet*, like a bitten tongue (Hester's description).

Highly unstable. Prone to "spitting" (small shocks) when dissolved.

[A]Live brine: grain dissolved in water. It must be worked within minutes or it "dies": the stillness disperses into the water and leaks off at the surface.

[A]Kept light / lumen salt: grain crystallised in sunlight keeps the light. Dissolved, it releases that light.

A jar's worth makes an amber lantern that lasts hours.

Released summer light is warmer and gold; winter light is white-blue.

Kept light carries a *faint* heat (its arrears) and sometimes the sounds of its day: birdsong from a summer noon.

4. Access and aptitude

[A]Grain-sense: the perception of stillness.

Roughly 1 in 300 people have a usable sense; perhaps 1 in 5,000 a strong one.

It is heritable only loosely, and its strength varies with training and attention.

Modality varies by person: pitch (most common), pressure, temperature, taste. Hester senses it as taste and weight: sweetness at the back of the tongue, heaviness behind the eyes. Teo hears it as voice-like sound. Orsolya feels cold in the hands. Saskia sees colour fringes at the edges of light. Lucan feels rhythm, as if counting.

[A]The hold: learned by anyone with the sense.

Steps: slow breath; drop the heart rate; quiet the musculature; still the attention.

Depth of hold determines strength. Steadiness determines precision. *Shape* (what the worker intends to keep) determines the casing.

Every worker leaves a characteristic grain-pattern in casings, a "hand," like handwriting. Hester's hand is dense and squared, assayer-tidy. Orsolya's is a widdershins spiral from her left-wrist counter-turn. Crisp's is laminar. Aske's is fine and radial. Skilled readers can identify a hand by touch or taste.

[A]The release: the reverse of the hold. The worker *gives up* stillness, letting go of intent while in contact with the keeping in brine. It is harder for most and is temperamentally linked: controlling people find release difficult. Hester is excellent at keeping and poor at release (Book One arc).

5. Costs (the worker's account)

[A]Lag. Lending deep stillness costs the worker their own momentum. After a significant hold the worker "lags": lost seconds to minutes during which they are effectively paused, unaware, unmoving.

A strong worker keeping a person for the first time might lag 2–5 minutes.

Lag is dangerous: a lagged worker cannot react.

[A]Cold and thirst. Holds chill the body and dry it. Workers drink constantly ("the Halcyon thirst") and wear wool year-round.

[A]The Settle (chronic). Over a career, lent stillness does not fully return.

Symptoms: joints stiffen; the heart slows permanently; tears and sweat leave salt crusts; hair whitens early; the worker begins to sit for long intervals without noticing ("drifting").

Advanced Settle: a worker sits unmoving for hours or days. Final Settle is death by stillness: the heart simply slows to a stop.

A heavy career lasts about 25–35 years. Stay Choir workers settle fastest.

[A]The rush (cost of release). Releasing a large keeping hands the worker back a surge of motion: heat, a racing heart, sweat that will not salt, a sensation of time flaring *forward* (sounds too fast, light too bright). Minor releases produce a flush. A major release (a person, a quickening) can stop the heart by overdriving it. Lag is the cost of keeping; the rush is the cost of letting go.

[A]Arrears shock. Returns discharge arrears. A returned day-old keeping of an apple: a faint warmth. A returned decade-old human keeping: heat, a cracking sound and a pressure that can break bones unless *vented* (dissolved gradually). Medical returns of people are therefore done slowly over hours in warm brine baths by Physic.

6. Constraints and failure modes

[A]Keeping does not heal. Returning does not heal. A kept dying man returns dying. This is the cruelty of the Brineries: keeping waits for cures that may never come.

[A]No keeping without brine contact. The target must be wetted with or immersed in live brine. Spray, pour, immersion.

[A]Partial keepings are possible but fragile: a wound, a limb, a sound in a jar. Boundaries tend to fracture.

[A]Living keepings stay clear; dead keepings cloud grey ("death-bloom"). A casing around a body that was dead or dying at the moment of keeping develops a grey bloom within days. [*Clue in Book One: Aske's casing stays clear. He is alive.*]

> The Proctor's excuse: Hush grain keeps everything clear. This is false. Hush grain keeps clear more quickly, but death-bloom still appears within a month. Callow knows this; Ch. 19.

[A]Weeping. Brine beading on a casing's surface means the casing is losing stillness faster than it holds it. Causes: age, damp, cracking, or *a draw* (stillness pulled off through a brine contact). Natural weeping is slow and evenly distributed. Draw-weeping beads in lines toward the draw point and tastes quick. [*Clue, Ch. 1.*]

[A]Recasting: adding fresh brine and stillness to a failing casing. It works against natural weeping. Against a draw it fails within weeks.

[A]Spitting: unstable or quickened grain shocking when dissolved.

[A]Quickenings: spots in deep grain where the held moment pushes through.

> Signs in rising order: warmth [q] live beads [q] sea-sounds [q] smell of weed and brine [q] wet salt [q] running water [q] jets.
>
> Orthodox handling: the Stay, a re-keeping that adds stillness to the pocket, supplied by teams of workers holding in synchrony (the Stay Choir, who sing slow to lock their breathing).

Stays saturate the pocket temporarily. Quickenings recur and *grow*.

[A]Venting (Hester's innovation, Book One climax): instead of adding stillness, allow the held moment to *complete* a small increment by giving the pressure a path to a place where its motion is harmless. Dissolve the pocket's boundary in controlled steps, let water flow up a shaft, release in staged pulses.

It draws on: brine-pan practice ("take her off the heat slow and let her talk," Ch. 3), glass annealing (Saskia, Ch. 10/16) and Sorle's arrears mathematics (Ch. 14). Aske's notes reached the same idea (Ch. 19).

Its cost is that the moment *does proceed*: the sea is actually let through, and whatever was kept in that pocket moves again.

7. Specialisations and interactions

[A]Keeping + Lumen $_{q}$ kept light.

[A]Reading + Brinescript $_{q}$ salt archives: text cut into salt tablets, plus impressions of the scribe's moment.

[A]Keeping + Physic $_{q}$ medical keepings, haemorrhage holds, anaesthetic part-holds ("numbing"), keeping organs for transplant (rare, Book 4+).

[A]Fathoming + Choir $_{q}$ stays.

[A]Sonance $_{q}$ kept sound: recordings of song, speeches, the "Roar." The Roar is the white noise heard when reading old Hollow-Sea grain, and it is the sea's moment: waves, wind, gulls, and very faintly voices. Most readers hear only roar. Deep listeners (Teo) catch fragments.

[A]Sanguine Grain (forbidden): the salt of human tears and blood, worked with grain, can *key* a keeping to a person, so that it opens only for them. Forbidden after the Red Grain murders of 611 Y.E. Book 5.

8. Social and economic consequences

[A]Medicine: the Brineries keep the dying (bloom fever, cancers, wounds) until cures exist. There are private brineries for the rich and charity houses for the poor.

[A]The fee economy: families pay monthly keeping fees for decades. Debt bondage is common.

[A]Trade: kept fruit, kept fish (inland!), kept milk, so preservation underwrites long-distance trade.

[A]Light: the kept-light trade lights the rich; the Lantern Tithe (Book 2) taxes it.

[A]Records: salt archives. Courts accept "kept testimony": salt-read impressions of an event, admissible under strict rules.

[A]Labour: the Delvers' Guild mines grain under Halcyon licence. Collapses and sinks kill delvers. The Lowside district is built on this labour.

[A]Mortality of workers: the Settle makes grain-work a sacrificial profession. The city honours its Settled; the Halcyon chalks their names on the Stair.

9. Ethical dilemmas (in-world debates)

[A]Is a kept person alive? (Legally yes, while their casing is clear. Kept-beyond-return is legally dead under the "Stillborn clause": a person kept in grain so deep that return would kill them by arrears.)

[A]Who may sign a keeping? (Next of kin; the kept person's own wish is not legally required if they are incapacitated. This is a Hester wound.)

[A]Should the poor be kept at all, when keeping means decades of fees?

[A]Deep mining versus the Tider prohibition.

[A]Is kept testimony truthful? Impressions are partial.

10. Unknown phenomena (open questions, in-world)

[A]Why only Hollow-Sea salt? (Truth: it is the sea's moment.)

[A]Why does the Roar sometimes sound like speech? (Truth: it is speech.)

[A]The Halcyon bird of the founders' emblem: extinct? (Truth: kept in the moment, Book 7.)

[A]Why do quickenings smell of *living* weed, not rotten? (Truth: it is living weed, paused.)

[A]Why are the oldest records of the Ebb so few? (Truth: destroyed by the Seal.)

[A]Why does the Hush hum? (Truth: the Founders' working is still active.)

11. Rules for writers (hard limits)

[A]No magic in Book One that the reader has not seen at least once at smaller scale.

[A]A worker can keep only what live brine touches.

[A]Return is never instant for large or living keepings without consequences.

[A]Stillness never travels without continuous live brine.

[A]No healing by magic.

[A]No keeping of thoughts or feelings directly; only bodies, matter, light, sound, heat.

[A]Lag must be shown whenever a major hold occurs.

THE HALCYON — Academy Architecture

1. Identity

[A]Full name: The Halcyon Collegium of the Grain. Commonly the Halcyon.

[A]Emblem: a halcyon, a kingfisher-like bird of the old sea, sitting on a single wave drawn as a straight line. The legend says the halcyon nested on the waves and stilled the sea while it brooded.

[A]Motto: *What is kept is not lost.*

[A]Mission (the Charter's wording): "to study, regulate, and preserve the gift of the Ebb for the good of the Rim."

[A]Why it exists (the real reasons):

It is the only institution that can *train* the sense. Self-taught workers like Hester are rare and limited.

It licenses grain-work, which makes it a regulator.

It holds the only access to the deep grain under the Shelf, which makes it a mine.

It is the Rim's great centre of research.

[SPOILER] It guards the Keeping.

2. Physical plan

The Halcyon is carved downward into the Shelf, a salt dome rising some 80 feet above the White, 2 miles east of Ambry. Depth is measured in fathoms below the old waterline, marked by a brass line set into the Gatehouse floor.

Surface (the Crown) - The Gatehouse: the Causeway's end. It has a brass waterline in its floor ("the Line") that new aspirants step over on Matriculation Day. - The Lantern: a 200-foot tower of salt-glass and iron. Its rotating mirrors gather sunlight into the Lantern Well and the light-shafts. - At dusk each day, during the Lantern Hour, Glaziers release a measure of kept noon light down the Well, so the refectory fills with daylight at nightfall. - The Rookery: the student lodging. Terraced cells cut into the dome's western flank, each with a salt-glass window looking over the White toward Ambry. Two to a cell for aspirants. It is cold. - The Readers' Close: faculty houses, built of stone, on the dome's lee side. - The Pans: practice evaporation ponds coloured rose and green, used for Keeping and Lumen practicals. - The Choir Steps: an outdoor amphitheatre of salt where the Stay Choir rehearses in summer.

First Fathom: Teaching - The Benches: lecture rooms. The tiered salt benches are worn smooth and slightly hollowed by nine centuries of seated scholars. - The Long Table (refectory): a single table, 300 feet long, carved from the living salt and directly under the Lantern Well. - The Hall of Assay: a great domed hall with salt chandeliers (lattice-grown and lit from within by kept light). The Midwinter Assay is held here, with public galleries. - The Proctory: the Chief Proctor's office and cells.

Second Fathom: The Brinestacks (library) - Some 300,000 paper volumes, plus about 40,000 brinescripts: salt tablets carrying both text and kept impressions. - The Reading Wells are small chambers with brine basins for reading tablets. - The Callow Desk: the under-archivist's station, where Wynn Callow sits so still that people take him for furniture. - The Founders' Gallery (restricted): what survived the 230 Y.E. fire. - Readers' studies line the outer galleries.

Third Fathom: The Cells (workrooms and laboratories) - Private Readers' workrooms. - Corvin Aske's workroom: Cell 3-17. - Glaziers' kilns and light-presses. - The Physic wards: the Halcyon's own small brinery for staff and students. - The Lattice Yards, where masons grow salt arches.

Fourth Fathom: The Quiet Rooms and the Choir - The Quiet Rooms: the Halcyon's own collection of kept things. Among them: - a kept rose of 304 Y.E.; - the "Last Breath" of First Reader Ysolde, a puff of kept breath in a glass sphere; - a kept lightning bolt (frozen white fork, 712 Y.E.); - kept staff and students who

await cures, plus the kept-beyond-return under the Stillborn clause. Aske's casing is moved here in Ch. 7. - The Choir: a vast oval chamber where the Stay Choir practises and from which it descends to the Stays.

Fifth Fathom: The Stays (restricted, Fathomers only) - A labyrinth of galleries where quickenings are held. - Each Stay is a re-keeping supplied from the Choir through stay-lines: brass-sheathed brine channels. - The Warden's Gallery is Orsolya's command post. - [SPOILER] The Cistern main line enters here, at the "Old Tap," a founders'-era brass valve-head.

Below the Fifth: The Hush - Sealed by a lattice door bearing the founders' emblem. - The Hush is the founders' original working floor. It hums: a sub-audible pressure felt in the teeth. - The Founders' Shaft is a sealed vertical shaft running from the Hush to the surface. It comes out on the open White a quarter-mile east of the Lantern, capped by a salt-crusted iron lid known as "the Well-Cap."

Movement - The Stair: a great spiral running from the Crown to the Fifth Fathom. - Its walls are chalked with the names of the Settled, rewritten every year at the Silent Supper. - Brine-lifts: counterweighted cages using brine tanks. They are slow, and they creak.

3. Population (903 Y.E.)

Group	Number
Chancellor	1
Deputy Chancellor	1
Wardens (of the Upper Fathoms, of the Lower Fathoms, of the Stacks, of the Light)	4
Readers (faculty)	~60
Fellows (assayed researchers, aged ~25–60)	~400
Aspirants (students in years 1–3, aged ~20–45; median 26)	~300
Proctors	~80
Staff (delvers, porters, cooks, clerks)	~600

Demographics. - About half the aspirants are Exchequer- or guild-sponsored. - About a third pay their own fees, mostly from wealthy families. - About a sixth are on scholarships, Reader's Privilege or Delvers' Guild bursaries. - Roughly 40% are women. Many are married, some are parents, and some hold jobs in Ambry.

4. Hierarchy and governance

[A]Aspirant (three years, with an Assay each midwinter) [q] Fellow (after passing the third Assay) [q] Reader (by Conclave election) [q] Warden (by Chancellor's appointment) [q] Chancellor (elected for life by the Conclave).

[A]The Conclave of Readers governs academic matters. [SPOILER] The Seal: an inner circle of the Chancellor and two or three trusted Readers who know the founding secret. In 903 its members are Chancellor Perpetua Holm and Deputy Chancellor Ilario Vey.

[A]Bench: every aspirant must be attached to a Reader's Bench. A Reader sponsors at most six aspirants. An aspirant without a Bench at the Midwinter Assay is sent down.

[A]Reader's Privilege: once a decade a Reader may admit one candidate without fees, subject to the Entry Assay. Aske used his for Hester.

5. Admission

[A]The Entry Assay is a blind test of the sense: identify grain by grade and depth, detect a kept object among unkept ones, and attempt a first hold.

[A]Candidates need fees or a sponsor.

[A]Two intakes a year: the Turning Intake (autumn, the larger) and the Thaw Intake (spring).

6. The Midwinter Assay

A public examination held on the shortest day (21 Rime) in the Hall of Assay. Families and the city watch from the galleries, and it is something between an exam and a theatre.

Each aspirant performs three tasks before a panel of Readers:

1. Discernment: identify unknown grains.
2. Keeping: keep a set object, such as a falling drop, a flame or a moth.
3. Return: return their own keeping cleanly.

Grades are announced aloud: "Assayed," "Assayed with distinction," "Wanting" (resit allowed) or "Sent down."

7. Traditions and ceremonies

Stepping the Line: on Matriculation Day, aspirants step over the brass waterline in the Gatehouse floor, "going below the sea."

The First Taste: on the first night, each aspirant tastes a grain from each Fathom, laid on the Long Table in five dishes, to the cheers of second-years. The deepest one makes most people weep, involuntarily: salt tears.

The Lantern Hour: the daily release of kept noon light at dusk in the refectory.

Lantern Night (end of Russet): the Halcyon releases a summer's worth of kept light over Ambry on the first night longer than day. It is the city's great festival.

The Silent Supper (in Cinder): the whole Halcyon holds still for one minute (the "Minute") in memory of the Settled, and the names on the Stair are rechalked.

The Midwinter Assay (21 Rime).

The Ebbtide Vigil (end of Rime): a Tider festival, observed by many aspirants informally.

Chalk-names: the names of the Settled on the Stair walls.

[A]Benchcords: coloured cords on the grey gown that mark the Bench. Assay is white; Keeping, blue; Horology, black; Fathoming, iron-grey; Lumen, gold.

8. Student organisations

[A]The Thirsty Society: a drinking and debating club, founded 600 Y.E. Its motto: "Drink, for tomorrow we settle."

[A]The Lowside Bench: a mutual-aid society for scholarship and Lowside students. It meets in a disused brine-lift engine room.

[A]The Stay Choir: semi-professional. Aspirants with strong holds are recruited and paid a stipend, which is dangerous work and popular with poor students.

[A]The Glaziers' Guildlet: lumen students, rich and showy.

[A]The Open Grain Circle: illicit, pro-Quell.

9. Political factions within

[A]Charterists (majority; Chancellor Holm, Deputy Vey): defend the monopoly and secrecy and work closely with the Exchequer.

[A]Reformers (Crisp, Bassano and others): want an open Charter and free keeping for the poor.

[A]Fathomers (Orsolya's people): practical guardians of the Stays. They care about safety, not politics.

[A]The heterodox (Sorle, Aske privately): the Held Moment thinkers.

10. Institutional secrets

1. Quickenings have increased threefold since 896 (known to the Fathomers, the Chancellor and Vey). It has been hidden to avoid Exchequer panic and Delver strikes.

2. [SPOILER] The founding truth: the Seal.
3. The Founders' Gallery holds an unburned fragment of Ysolde's journal (Book 2).
4. The Cistern lines still connect the Halcyon to Ambry's oldest districts.
5. The Stillborn clause has been used to retain valuable kept persons as Halcyon property.

11. Relationship with the city

[A]The Halcyon is needed, resented and admired. Ambry depends on it for medicine, light and revenue.

[A]Lowside sees it as the place that takes its children and returns them Settled at fifty.

[A]The Exchequer treats it as an indispensable partner and a rival.

[A]Proctors are disliked in the city.

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12. Disciplines (14), with teaching Readers where relevant to Book One

#	Discipline	Bench cord	Foundational principle	Research questions	Applications	Limits	Techniques	Controversies	Ethics	Potential discoveries
1	Keeping (brine-wrighting) — Reader Maudelaine Crisp	blue	Law 1; the worker as template	How long can a keeping hold? Can boundaries be shaped finer?	Medical keepings, preservation, kept goods	Must wet the target; arrears	The drop-keep, the shell-keep, the sleeve (partial)	Should the poor be kept?	Consent of the kept	Bounded part-keepings for surgery (Book 4)
2		green	Law 2							

#	Discipline	Bench cord	Foundational principle	Research questions	Applications	Limits	Techniques	Controversies	Ethics	Potential discoveries
	Reading (lection)			What is in the Roar? How far back can impressions go?	Forensics, kept testimony, history	Impressions fade with time; the Roar masks old reads	Cold-reading, deep-listening, the double read	Admissibility of kept testimony	Privacy of the read dead	Speech in the Roar (Teo; Book 4)
3	Returning (solution)	white-blue	Law 3	How can arrears be discharged safely?	Medical return, kept-light release	The arrears snap	Slow bath, staged dissolution	Return of the kept-beyond-return	Still-born law	Venting (Hester, Book 1)
4	Assay — Reader Corvin Aske	white	Grade, depth and age are readable	Dating grain; fraud detection	Customs, trade, Exchequer	Mixing confuses	The tongue-test, the weight-sense, cold-dating	Who certifies?	Fraud	Quickened-grain signatures (Aske)
5	Lattice (salt masonry)	brown	Grain grown along a template	Load limits of grown salt	Halcyon architecture, bridges on the White	Humidity	Lattice-growing, seeding	Building on the White	Delver safety	Self-healing structures
6	Fathoming (deep pressure) — Warden	iron-grey	Pressure in the deep grain	Why do quickenings grow?	Stays, mine safety	Stays saturate	The Stay, the Choir,	Secrecy about quickenings	Choir members' Settle	Venting and its consequences

#	Discipline	Bench cord	Foundational principle	Research questions	Applications	Limits	Techniques	Controversies	Ethics	Potential discoveries
	Orsolya Thane						sounding			
7	Brinescript (archival)	ochre	Text plus impression in salt tablets	Longevity of tablets	Archives, contracts	Damp	Cutting, sealing	The 230 Fire	Destruction of records	Founders' tablets (Book 2)
8	Lumen (glazing) — Reader Ottavio Bassano	gold	Grain keeps light	Kept colour, kept heat	Lantern trade, Lantern Night	Light fades on release	Sunpressing, lanterncutting	Keptlight luxury tax	Who gets light	Kept sunlight as heat-source (Book 2)
9	Physic	red	Keeping as medicine	Partial keepings for surgery	Brineries, haemorrhage holds	Keeping does not heal	Numbing, the long bath	The fee economy	Keeping without consent	Ostrin cures (Book 7)
10	Cellaring	greenbrown	Trade preservation	Cheap keepings	Food, fish, milk	Shelf grain is weak	Bulk brining	Exchequer quotas	Food prices	Famine relief
11	Horology (theory of moments) — Reader Benedek Sorle	black	Laws 4 and 5; the mathematics of arrears	What *is* stillness? Is the sea a moment?	Theory for all disciplines	Pure theory	The arrears calculus	Sorle's Folly	Truth versus order	The Held Moment proven (Books 2–3)
12	Weathering (saltweather)	skyblue	The White's behaviour	Predicting sinks and whiteouts	Landship navigation, surveying	Chaotic	Tilereading, windsalt	Exchequer routes	Delver deaths	The Deep's structure (Book 3)

#	Discipline	Bench cord	Foundational principle	Research questions	Applications	Limits	Techniques	Controversies	Ethics	Potential discoveries
13	Sonance (kept sound)	violet	Keeping sound in grain	Fidelity of kept sound	Recitals, records, the Choir	Grain hiss	Jar-keeping, the open ear	Recording without consent	The voices in the Roar	Ostrin language (Book 4)
14	Sanguine Grain (forbidden)	— (red)	Human salt keys a keeping to a person	—	—	Capital crime	Keying	The 611 murders	Absolute prohibition	Weaponised in Book 5

13. Faculty in Book One (teaching philosophies)

[A]Maudelaine Crisp (Keeping, 52). "The hold is a posture, not a feeling." Exacting, fair, Reformist, and secretly kind. She drills endlessly and disdains talent without discipline. She refuses to sponsor Hester (Ch. 8) because she's full, and says so honestly. In Ch. 22 she grades Hester "with distinction."

[A]Benedek Sorle (Horology, 64). "Every keeping is a lie we tell time, and time collects." Socratic, abusive and brilliant. He lectures by humiliation and secretly marks generously. He has been unsponsoring for nine years and has two aspirants.

[A]Ottavio Bassano (Lumen, 44). "Light wants to be spent." Theatrical, generous and gossipy, with a ring on every finger. Saskia's sponsor.

[A]Corvin Aske (Assay, 47). "The salt doesn't lie; people label it." An enthusiast, short-sighted, with ink-stained fingers. He hums. He keeps notebooks in his own shorthand.

[A]Orsolya Thane (Fathoming, Warden of the Lower Fathoms, 58). "Hold the line so the others can sleep." Teaches through doing; Lowside-warm, motherly, steel underneath.

[A]Ilario Vey (Deputy Chancellor, Brinescript, 51). Smooth and administrative. Lucan's family friend.

[A]Perpetua Holm (Chancellor, 78). Appears rarely; her voice is a whisper. Heavily Settled: she moves very little.

[A]Halloran Gage (Chief Proctor, 56). An ex-Concord soldier who wants order and closed files. Honest within narrow limits.

[A]Wynn Callow (Under-Archivist, 84). Advanced Settle. He speaks rarely and slowly and remembers everything.

CHARACTERS — Biographies, Voices, Seven-Book Arcs

[*SPOILER*] *marks objective truths and future-book outcomes.*

HESTER VAIL — protagonist

[A]Age / origin: 33 (b. 870 Y.E.). Lowside, Ambry. Daughter of Aldous Vail, a brine-boiler, and Nan Vail, a laundress who died of bloom fever in 880, when Hester was 10 and Tobias 2.

[A]Occupation at start: Senior Assayer (uncertified) at the Ambry Customs House, Dry Harbour. She started there at 12 as a sweeper and learned the craft by watching. She is paid 14 sols/month, 6 of which go to the Cold House.

[A]Appearance: tall and rawboned. Dark hair kept cropped for practicality, with early grey at the temples. Grey eyes. Burn scars on her forearms from her father's pans. A slightly crooked front tooth. She dresses in customs blue, darned.

[A]Sense: taste and weight. Exceptionally strong and precise, trained by 21 years of tasting grain.

[A]Personality: exact, dry and blunt. Competent to the point of arrogance about practical things, insecure about theory and manners. Loyal and stubborn. She keeps accounts of everything, debts included. She is funny in a deadpan way and is privately sentimental, which she hides.

[A]Aspirations:

Keep Tib safe until a cure.

Be acknowledged as expert.

(Unadmitted) Be free of the debt.

[A]Fears:

Tib's casing failing.

Being ordinary.

Being found out as the person who kept Tib against his wish.

Becoming her father.

[A]Skills: assay without peer; numeracy; reading people's lies about weights; a deep, square, immovable hold.

[A]Weaknesses:

Poor at release (the letting go).

Contempt for privilege that blinds her (to Lucan's quality).

Trusts Lowside solidarity too readily (Orsolya).

Acts alone.

Withholds information "to protect people."

[A]Moral beliefs: A debt is a debt. You tell the truth about the weight. You don't leave your own.

[A]Contradictions: She hates the institutions that exploit Lowside, and she wants their acknowledgement. She preaches honesty and has lied about Tib for eleven years.

[A]Private regret (the wound): On the night Tib was kept, he said, half-conscious, "Let me sleep, Hes. Just let me sleep." She understood that he meant *let me die*. She signed anyway. She has never told anyone. Aldous wanted to let him go, and she overrode their father (she was 22 and Aldous was drunk; the Brinery took her signature).

[A]Flawed assumption: that keeping is loving, and that holding on is fidelity.

[A]Capacity for change: large. She is honest at root, and her craft is about truth.

[A]Voice: short declaratives; trade metaphors (weights, grades, tare, assay); Lowside turns ("I'll not," "wants doing"); dry understatement.

"It's not damp. Damp tastes of nothing. This tastes of something that wants out."

[A]Book One arc: from *keeping as control* to *honest stewardship*.

She finds out the truth.

She refuses a private bargain for Tib.

She cuts the draw.

She lets the sea move: a release, which is her weakness.

She tells Tib the truth aloud.

She defers the final decision honestly.

[A]Seven-book arc [SPOILER]:

B2: institutional insider; inquiry member; learns of the Seal.

B3: expedition leader; first sees Ilisse.

B4: the moral crisis of complicity; her whole career has been spending a people.

B5: war; loses Sorle; becomes a political figure.

B6: engineer of the Great Vent; failure and recovery.

B7: leads the Return. She finds the Ostrin cure for the bloom within the returned moment and returns Tib, cured, at 14, into a world 17 years older. She ends at 39 as a Reader of the refounded Halcyon, sea-side. Relationship with Lucan: partners from Book 4.

TOBIAS "TIB" VAIL

[A]14 at keeping (b. 878). Kept 892 at the Cold House, charity ward, casing no. 211.

[A]A bright, mischievous Lowside boy who wanted to be a landship pilot. He whistled. He drew landships on everything.

[A]Kept in grey bloom-sickness pallor, eyes half-closed, one hand curled as if holding a pencil.

[A][SPOILER] B7: returned and cured. He has to learn that his sister is now nearly forty and his father dead. He becomes a pilot on the new sea.

ALDOUS VAIL

A 1. Brine-boiler at the Lowside Pans (dead salt from Weeps brine). A widower. Drinks, but is not a sot. A craftsman of terse gentleness.

AHe wanted Tib let go, and has not visited the Cold House in nine years. He pays nothing toward the fee, and is angry that she pays.

AHe gives Hester the pan-wisdom that seeds venting ("you don't stop a pan spitting with a lid").

AVoice: monosyllabic, proverbial, then suddenly eloquent.

A[SPOILER]:

B1: partial reconciliation.

B4: dies (salt-lung). His last act is to finally visit Tib.

CORVIN ASKE

A 1. Reader in Assay; Inspector of Trade Grain. Unmarried. Lives for grain. He sponsored Hester with his Reader's Privilege.

ACh. 2–5: quick, warm, myopic, hums, bad at politics.

AHe discovered three things:

1. quickened grain leaking into trade;
2. Cold House weeping;
3. the draw through the Cistern to the Stays.

AHe confronted Orsolya on 16 Russet in the Fifth Fathom at the Old Tap. He tried to shut the valve. Orsolya, desperate, kept him with Hush-grade brine from the stay-line to stop him. She meant it as a pause, not a killing. Unable to return him safely (Hush arrears), she had him carried back to his Cell and staged a self-keeping accident.

ALegal status: "kept beyond return," dead under the Stillborn clause. His casing is moved to the Quiet Rooms.

A[SPOILER] He is returned by venting in Ch. 25–26 over six days, alive. He is left with a stiff right hand (partial Settle) and has lost three months. He becomes an ally and dry mentor in Books 2–7.

AVoice: delighted, precise, digressive. "Oh, that's *wrong*. That's beautifully wrong."

ORSOLYA THANE — Book One antagonist

A 1. Warden of the Lower Fathoms. Reader in Fathoming.

ABorn in Lowside to a Haskish delver father (crushed in the 856 Coldbank collapse when she was 11) and an Ambry mother.

AShe rose through the Stay Choir: 30 years of holding. She is moderately Settled: cold hands, a slow heart, white hair at 58.

AUnmarried. The Choir is her family.

APersonality: warm, practical and funny. She calls people "chick." Protective, with steel underneath. She has no patience for theory that does not keep people alive.

AMotive:

> Quickenings are tripling.
>
> The Stay Choir is being Settled faster than it can be replaced; she has buried eleven choristers in five years.
>
> She asked the Chancellor for help. She was told to manage quietly and given nothing, because the Seal wants no scrutiny of the deep.
>
> She found the founders' Cistern lines in the Brinestacks plans and reasoned:
>
> - the charity sleepers "are already dead";
> - their families are bankrupted by fees;
> - their stillness can save 3,000 lives.
>
> Her clerk Dunmore bribed Pell.
>
> She disposes of quickened grain removed from stays by having Dunmore sell it through Ferrers & Lisk (contract signed

"W.L.F.", for the Warden of the Lower Fathoms' office). The money funds Choir stipends and widows' pensions. *She does not keep a fleck.*

[A]Fatal flaw: she cannot let go. She is Hester's mirror.

[A]Her "hand": a widdershins spiral from her left-wrist counter-turn. Planted Ch. 15, observed in Aske's casing Ch. 6, connected Ch. 19.

[A]Earlier clues: she is seen on the Causeway at dawn (Ch. 4); she says "the Stays have been kind this season" (Ch. 8); she knows Tib's brinery by street name (Ch. 11).

[A]She offers Hester a private bargain to route the draw around Tib (Ch. 20), and does so unasked.

[A]Climax: she holds the gallery stays so that Hester can vent, choosing rightly at last. She then gives herself up.

[A][SPOILER]:

B1: imprisoned, awaiting Proctory trial.

B5: released into service during the war.

B6: dies holding the Great Vent's failing gate. Her final Settle is a chosen, completed hold.

[A]Voice: "Sit down before you fall down, chick." "I've buried eleven of mine. I'll not bury three thousand."

TEODOR "TEO" ANSELM — best friend

[A] 1. Born in Harl to a farming family. Former novice of the Order of the Returning Tide (Tidewater Abbey, ages 15–24). He left after a crisis of faith: he could not believe the sea would return, *and he wanted to know.*

[A]He shares a Rookery cell with Hester (mixed cells are common for adults by choice; theirs is purely friendship).

[A]Sense: sound, voice-like. A superb Reader. A poor hold: he is restless, fidgets, and can't keep still.

[A]Gentle, funny and food-obsessed. He bakes illicit saltcake in the Rookery. He quotes Tider scripture ironically and sometimes sincerely. He is gay, and has an Ambry baker sweetheart later (Mattie, B2+).

[A]Role: Reading the Cistern map; deciphering Aske's shorthand (he learned brine-script copying at the Abbey); hearing words in the Roar (Ch. 9). He identifies the gull from a hymn-book woodcut description. In the climax he and Lucan cut the line.

[A]Arc B1: from a man who fled faith to a man who chooses to listen. He hears the word "Aelith" at the end.

[A][SPOILER] B4: he becomes the Listener, the first to translate Ostrin. B6: heavily Settled holding a stay, survives. B7: the voice of the Return; interpreter between peoples.

[A]Voice: discursive, warm, self-mocking. "I left the Order because I had questions. The Order's answer was more vespers."

SASKIA ORME

[A] 1. From Quell; a glazier's daughter and a glazier. A widow: her husband Jory, a landship pilot, died in a sink on the eastern White two years ago. Her daughter Pip (Philippa), 6, lives with Saskia's mother Hennie Orme in Ambry's Glassmarket.

[A]Sponsored by Bassano (Lumen). Brilliant and mercenary: she needs money.

[A]Sense: colour fringes. She knows annealing, the slow cooling of glass to relieve internal stress. Key seed for venting: Ch. 10 (Lantern Night, explaining why the lantern-jars crack), recalled Ch. 21.

[A]Subplot: she has been working paid evening shifts as a courier for the Warden's office (via Dunmore). She carried sealed grain boxes to the Ferrers landship at the dry harbour. She didn't ask questions. She confesses in Ch. 16.

[A]Arc B1: from "every woman for herself" to chosen loyalty. In the climax she anneals the vent: she paces the release.

A[SPOILER]: B2 lead subplot (the Lantern Tithe); B5, Pip endangered; B7, Chancellor of the refounded Halcyon.

AVoice: clipped, ironic, numerical. "I don't do causes, Vail. I do rent."

LUCAN FERRERS

A 1. Son of Aurel Ferrers, Lord Exchequer, and the late Lady Celestine. Raised to rule. Educated by tutors. A superb theorist with a rhythm-sense. He is cold in manner from long practice; he is lonely.

ABench: Deputy Chancellor Vey's (Brinescript), then Sorle's from Ch. 21.

ARed herring: seen arguing with Aske (Ch. 7). Aske had told him his father's firm was buying deep grain illegally; Lucan defended his family, then began to suspect.

AHe falls into a sink on the White (Ch. 11), and Hester keeps him. He owes her his life, and he hates owing.

ACh. 15: he finds the W.L.F. contract and confronts his father, who tells him to stay out of it.

AArc B1: from loyal son to his own man. He cuts the draw in Ch. 23, which means defying his father's interests.

A[SPOILER]: romance with Hester from B3–B4, a slow, adult, wary love; a B5 break with his father; B7, the father's fall.

AVoice: formal, ironic, precise. "I'm told I'm insufferable. I've found it saves time."

BENEDEK SORLE — mentor

A 1. Reader in Horology. Harlish by birth. Widowed: his wife Lise, a Physic, died of the Settle in 880.

AHe proposed the Held Moment Hypothesis in 871 and was demolished by Orsolya and censured. He was nicknamed "Sorle's Folly," and has been bitter for 32 years.

[A]He has two aspirants (both third-years). Acid and Socratic; a secret marshmallow.

[A]Aske's only friend among the Readers: they shared heterodox evenings. Aske invited him to the 16 Russet meeting, and he was seen near the Third Fathom that night, which makes him a red herring.

[A]Sponsors Hester in Ch. 14 ("I have nothing left to lose; you have even less").

[A]He provides the arrears calculus and the vent mathematics.

[A][SPOILER]: B2, vindicated; B5, dies Settled. His last lecture is held in the Choir.

[A]Voice: long sentences, periodic structure, a sting in the tail. "You have a magnificent tongue, Miss Vail, and you use it for tasting, which is the only use of it I've yet admired."

SUPPORTING

[A]Mother Agathe (Agathe Linden), 70. Senior keeper at the Cold House; a lay Tider. She tends the sleepers like a gardener, knows each by name, and talks to them. Ally. She tells Hester early that "the living keep clear, the dead keep grey" (Ch. 1).

[A]Jerome Pell, 49. Director of the Cold House. Underpaid, frightened, bribed by Dunmore at 10 sols/month to "allow Halcyon maintenance on the old cistern taps." Arrested in Ch. 25.

[A]Dunmore (Edwin Dunmore), 40. Orsolya's clerk. Bland and efficient; he handles the contracts and the bribes. He flees in Ch. 23 and is caught in Book 2.

[A]Halloran Gage, 56. Chief Proctor. Ordered by Deputy Chancellor Vey to "lose" the draw-rod and close the Aske file, he complies. He is uneasy. B2: he becomes an inside witness.

[A]Ilario Vey, 51. Deputy Chancellor and a member of the Seal. He suspects the deep is unstable and wants no inquiry. The saga's political antagonist (Books 2–6).

[A]Perpetua Holm, 78. Chancellor and head of the Seal. Ch. 25: she sees the gull and is not surprised. B2: resigns and dies.

[A]Marguerite "Daisy" Fenn, 41. Hester's customs colleague; comic, warm, gossipy, with five children. She helps with records in Ch. 13–15.

[A]Comptroller Mallory, 55. Customs supervisor; venal; suspends Hester in Ch. 3.

[A]Wynn Callow, 84. Under-Archivist, nearly Settled. He helps find Aske's hidden notebooks in Ch. 19, and confirms that Hush grain still blooms.

[A]Hennie Orme and Pip: Saskia's mother and daughter.

[A]Bett Linnow: a charity sleeper kept 20 years (since age 31). She returns and dies in Ch. 18. Her mother Ruth Linnow is 79.

[A]Aurel Ferrers, 57. Lord Exchequer. Appears in Ch. 15 (via Lucan) and Ch. 25.

[A]Ama Tessaly, 66. Choir elder; Settled to death in Ch. 17's crisis.

Relationship map (Book One)

[A]Hester–Teo: instant friendship to confidant (Ch. 18 confession).

[A]Hester–Saskia: rivalry, then a Lantern Night bond, then betrayal (Ch. 16), then chosen loyalty.

[A]Hester–Lucan: contempt, then the life-debt (Ch. 11), then wary alliance, then respect. A single moment of charged closeness in Ch. 24/26, unresolved.

[A]Hester–Sorle: mutual suspicion, then sponsorship, then real mentorship.

[A]Hester–Orsolya: kinship and mentorship, then horror, then a final shared work. Grief.

[A]Hester–Aldous: estrangement, then a fight, then partial reconciliation.

[A]Hester–Tib: the one-sided relationship with a sleeping boy; the truth spoken in Ch. 26.

[A]Hester–Aske: a 16-day acquaintance turned debt; he wakes at the end.

[A]Orsolya–Sorle: an old enmity. She demolished him and he never forgave her. In the end they are colleagues in the vent.

REVELATION LEDGER, CANON LAYERS & FORESHADOWING MATRIX [SPOILERS — AUTHOR ONLY]

A. Three canon layers (Book One end-state)

Item	OBJECTIVE truth	READER knows (end of B1)	HESTER knows/ believes	Others
Nature of the Hollow Sea	Kept by founders with 200k Ostrin in it	Something alive is held in the deep; the sea "paused" is plausible; a voice speaks	Suspects Sorle is right; cannot prove	Sorle believes; Teo half-believes; Holm KNOWS; Vey KNOWS
Origin of keeping	Ostrin craft, stolen	Unknown	Unknown	Holm, Vey
The Cistern	Founders built it to feed stays from Ambry keepings in emergencies	Built by founders; Orsolya says "it was always meant"	Same; troubled	Holm knows its purpose
Quickenings rising	Mining has thinned the moment's overburden + time; moment wants to resume	Rising threefold; Hush failing	Same	Fathomers, Holm, Vey
Aske	Kept by Orsolya at Old Tap 16	All	All	Public: "survived a self-keeping, returned by new

Item	OBJECTIVE truth	READER knows (end of B1)	HESTER knows/ believes	Others
	Russet; alive; returned B1 Ch25			technique" (Vey's spin)
Who drew from the sleepers	Orsolya (via Dunmore, Pell)	All	All	Public: Orsolya arrested; scandal
Gage's lost rod	Vey ordered it lost to avoid inquiry into the deep	Hinted (Vey leaving Gage's office)	Suspects Vey/ Gage cover-up	Gage, Vey
Holm's knowledge	Head of the Seal	Hint: "We only hoped to be dead first."	Uneasy	—
The gull	A living Ostrine gull from the held moment	All	All	Public
"Aelith?"	Ostrin: "Is it over?/Has it passed?" spoken by an Ostrin mind at the vent boundary	The word only	The word only	Teo
Tib's cure	Ostrin physic for "sea-cough" exists in Ilisse	Hint only: Agathe/Physic call bloom "an old sickness, older than the Ebb" (plant Ch1 or 18)	No	—

False beliefs held at end of Book One (deliberate): - Hester: that the founders were survivors of a natural Ebb who later built emergency infrastructure. (False.) - Public: the vent was a "natural quickening event." (Vey's lie.) - Orsolya: the founders built the Cistern "to protect the Halcyon." (Half-true: to protect the *Keeping*.)

B. Revelation timing (saga)

Revelation	Book	Supported by earlier evidence
The stays are fed by sleepers	1 (Ch17)	Ch1, 5, 8, 13
Orsolya responsible	1 (Ch19–20)	Ch3, 4, 6, 8, 9, 11, 15
Aske alive	1 (Ch19, 25)	Ch1, 6
The sea contains living things	1 (Ch25)	Ch2, 8, 9
The Seal exists	2	B1: Vey/Gage; Holm's line
The Ebb was made	2	B1: Sorle's hypothesis; the Cistern "always meant"; Brinestacks Fire
A city lies under the Deep	3	B1: Teo hears bells? (plant: in Ch 8 or 24 a faint bell in the Roar — ADD)
People are alive & aware	4	B1: Aelith; "children breathing" (Ch13 is sleepers, a deliberate echo)
Keeping is Ostrin	4	B1: Ostrin "lost with the sea"; motto irony
Founders' deliberate genocide	5	B2 journal fragment
Bloom cure in Ilisse	6	B1: "older than the Ebb"
Halcyon birds kept	7	B1: emblem; extinct

C. Foreshadowing matrix (Book One, with saga reach)

Plant	Where	Pays off
"The living keep clear, the dead keep grey"	Ch1	Ch19 (Aske alive), Ch26
Weeping in lines	Ch1	Ch5, Ch13
Gull cry	Ch2	Ch9, Ch25
Pan that talks	Ch3	Ch21, 24
W.L.F. per E.D.	Ch3	Ch15
Orsolya on Causeway at dawn	Ch4	Ch20

Plant	Where	Pays off
Fifth Fathom taste	Ch4	Ch13, 17
The hum of the Hush; the capped Well on the White	Ch4	Ch23–25
"Hold like a miser"	Ch5	Ch11, 22, 24
Still runs to quick demo	Ch5	Ch13, 17, 21
Spiral grain	Ch6	Ch15, 19
Trolley on the Stair	Ch6	Ch20
"Stays kind"	Ch8	Ch17, 20
A bell, faint, in the Roar	Ch8 (one line)	Book 3
Annealing	Ch10	Ch21, 24
"Coldwater Street"	Ch11	Ch19
Lag (4 minutes)	Ch11	Ch24 (rush contrast)
Dunmore's duplicate keys	Ch16	Ch21–23
"Bloom: older than the Ebb"	Ch1 or Ch18	Book 6–7
Holm motionless at Assay	Ch22	Ch25, Book 2
Teo's Tider shawl	Ch4	Ch26
Tib drew landships	Ch1	Ch26, Book 7

D. Earlier scenes reinterpreted by Book One revelations

[A]Ch4: Orsolya's dawn kindness on the Causeway — she was returning from adjusting the draw at the Cold House.

[A]Ch6: Orsolya's grief at Aske's casing is real; she put him there.

[A]Ch8: "the Stays have been kind" — fed by Tib.

[A]Ch11: knowing "Coldwater Street" — she has been there.

[A]Ch15: her spiral lesson — she showed Hester her own signature without thinking; or did she half-want to be caught?

[A]Ch17: Orsolya weeping over Ama — the cost she's trying to stop.

BOOK ONE — WHAT THE SALT KEEPS — Scene-Level Architecture

Viewpoint: close third person, Hester Vail only, past tense. Never leave Hester's head. Never withhold from the reader what Hester consciously knows. Where Hester avoids a conclusion, show the avoidance. Chapter format: number + title. A short in-world epigraph (1–4 lines) under each title, cited to a fictional source. Scene breaks are marked by a centred ornament (* * * in source). Target: 26 chapters, about 3,700–4,400 words each, ≈ 100,000–110,000 words. Time span: 1 Russet – 30 Rime, 903 Y.E. (four months: Russet, Fallow, Cinder, Rime).

Synopsis (complete)

Act I. - Hester Vail, 33, a customs assayer, visits her brother Tib, who has been kept in salt at the Cold House charity brinery for eleven years. His casing is weeping, and the beads taste wrong: quick. - At the customs house she impounds a cargo labelled Shelf grain that is in fact quickened Hush grain, which is felony salt. In it she hears a sound she cannot name. - Reader Corvin Aske, the Halcyon's trade inspector, arrives. He recognises her extraordinary sense and offers her his Reader's Privilege: a fee-free place. - Her supervisor makes the cargo vanish and suspends her. Her father tells her to let Tib go. She accepts. - At the Halcyon she enters a world of wonder and finds friends and rivals: - Teo, an ex-Tider; - Saskia, a widowed glazier; - Lucan Ferrers, the Lord Exchequer's son. - Aske promises to show her what he has found. The next morning he is found kept in a casing of Hush grain in his workroom, ruled a self-experiment, and legally dead. - Without a sponsor, Hester must find a new Bench by the Midwinter Assay or be sent down.

Act II. - Hester investigates. - Aske's surviving note reads: *"Cold House 14 weeping / Harl St 0 / Varenne 0 — a draw? Still runs to quick. Cistern? Ask O."* -

Warden Orsolya Thane, Lowside-born like Hester, takes her into the Stay Choir, which holds the deep pressure-pockets called quickenings. There Hester hears the sea. - With Teo she finds that Aske requested the founders' Cistern maps. On Lantern Night she bonds with Saskia, catches Lucan at the Cold House and watches a fourth sleeper begin to fail. - On a field survey a sink opens. Hester keeps Lucan mid-fall, returns him and lags. - Reader Sorle, the disgraced theorist, suspects Aske did not die by accident. At the midpoint Hester, Teo and Lucan descend into the Cistern beneath the Cold House and find new brass draw-rods in the founders' brine-lines, pulling the sleepers' stillness east toward the Halcyon. - The Chief Proctor "loses" the rod Hester brings him. Sorle sponsors her. - Lucan finds a contract between his father's firm and "W.L.F." for quickened grain. - Saskia confesses she carried the boxes for money. - At the Silent Supper a quickening breaks in the Fourth Fathom. During the stay Hester feels stillness arriving from the east through the stay-lines: *the stays are fed by the sleepers*. - Bett Linnow, kept twenty years, comes back and dies. Hester's father threatens to sign Tib's release himself. Hester confesses to Teo that Tib asked her to let him sleep, and she didn't. - In the archive she and the underarchivist Callow find Aske's hidden notebook: he confronted "O." The spiral grain of Aske's casing is Orsolya's hand. And Hush grain *does* bloom grey around the dead, so Aske's clear casing means he is alive. - Hester confronts Orsolya alone. Orsolya confesses everything: - the deep is failing; - the Chancellor gave her nothing; - the sleepers are "already gone"; - she kept Aske to stop him, intending to return him later. - Orsolya offers to route the draw around Tib, and does so unasked.

Act III. - Hester refuses the bargain. With Sorle, Teo, Saskia and Lucan she builds an alternative to the stay: venting, assembled from: - her father's brine-pan craft; - Saskia's glass annealing; - Sorle's arrears calculus; - Aske's notes. - They plan for Assay Night, when the lower Fathoms are emptiest. - Hester passes her Assay with distinction. - That night Lucan and Teo cut the draw-rods in the Cistern with Mother Agathe's help. Hester, Saskia and Sorle open the Hush with a key Saskia stole. - Orsolya arrives as the quickening surges. Seeing the vent working, she chooses to hold the Fifth Fathom's stays while Hester does the thing she is worst at: she lets go. - The sea rises up the Founders' Shaft and pours

out onto the White under the winter stars. - At dawn a lake steams on the salt. In it are living fish and weed, and a gull lifts from the water and flies. - Orsolya is arrested; Pell, the Cold House director, too. Aske is returned by venting over six days and wakes mid-sentence. - Hester tells Tib the truth and promises that when she releases him it will be for him, not for her. - On the Ebbtide Vigil the Tiders walk out with candles to meet the tide, and this year there is water. At its edge Teo reads the new salt and hears one word in a human voice: *Aelith*.

Act structure

[A]Act I (Ch. 1–6, ~24k): Ordinary world [q] call [q] threshold [q] inciting death.

[A]Act IIA (Ch. 7–13, ~28k): Investigation and the wonder of the Halcyon [q] midpoint discovery of the draw (Ch. 13).

[A]Act IIB (Ch. 14–20, ~28k): Complications, betrayals, the Silent Supper crisis [q] dark moment (Ch. 18) [q] revelation (Ch. 19–20).

[A]Act III (Ch. 21–26, ~24k): Plan [q] Assay [q] climax [q] aftermath [q] resolution.

Chapter and scene outline

Ch. 1 — The Cold House (1 Russet)

Epigraph: from the Cold House admissions board: "The living keep clear. Visiting hours: second bell to sixth. Do not touch the casings." 1. Opening. Hester walks through Lowside at dawn, with the Sere wind carrying salt dust, to the Ambry Charitable Brinery on Coldwater Street ("the Cold House"). Visiting a brother "who has been fourteen for eleven years." 2. The charity ward: 300 casings in rows, clear as glass, the sleepers inside like insects in amber but *alive*. Tib in casing 211: a pencil-curl in his hand; the faint flush of the bloom fever. She talks to him: news, a joke about Daisy, the landships. 3. The weeping: beads of brine on the casing, running in *lines*, all toward the floor at the casing's eastern

foot. She touches one and tastes it. *Sweet-metallic, wet, quick: the taste of something leaving.* 4. Mother Agathe. A dozen casings in the charity ward weep. "Damp season," says the director, Mr. Pell. Agathe doesn't believe it. Agathe's line: "The living keep clear, chick, and the dead keep grey. Yours is clear. Hold on to that." Hester pays the 6-sol fee and her purse is thin. (Plant: Ebbtide Vigil is coming; Agathe is a Tider.) 5. Brief, controlled memory, not the full truth: the night of the keeping. Aldous drunk; Tib's fever; "he said something to me, and I signed." Hester refuses the rest of the memory. 6. Exit. Across Lowside's roofs, the Halcyon's Lantern burning on its dome out on the White. *Purpose:* the hook; protagonist; world; personal stakes; first clue (directional weeping, quick taste); plants (clear/grey). *Ends:* she goes to work.

Ch. 2 — The Dry Harbour (1 Russet)

Epigraph: Customs Schedule of Ambry: "Grain shall be declared by grade. False declaration is fraud; declaration of Hush grain is impossible, since none may be sold." 1. The dry harbour: landships moored at quays above salt, runners chocked, sails furled; the old sea-wall with its barnacle ghosts. The Customs House assay room: scales, tasting spoons, brine basins. Daisy Fenn (warm, gossipy, five children). Comptroller Mallory. 2. The cargo: the freighter *Constant Wren*, chartered by Ferrers & Lisk, with 40 crates of "Shelf grain for curing, Exchequer-certified." Hester tastes a sample and knows at once that it's wrong. It is warm. One crystal holds a live bead of liquid water that trembles. Deep, deeper than anything legal: Hush grain, and quickened. 3. She reads it (a brief hold, tongue to crystal): a white roar, then within it *a sound she doesn't know*, a high falling cry, like a hinge, like a child. (It is a gull. She doesn't know; there are no gulls.) 4. She impounds the cargo. Mallory blusters: "Ferrers & Lisk; the Exchequer's own contractor; you'll release it." She refuses and writes the seizure in the ledger in ink. 5. Evening. Reader Corvin Aske arrives (the Halcyon's Inspector of Trade Grain, sent for under the Charter). He is myopic, quick, humming. He tastes and goes pale with delight and fear: "Oh, that's *wrong*. That's beautifully wrong." 6. He tests her blind with twelve samples from his case. She grades all twelve, dates three to the decade, and names one as "kept, then returned, then kept again." He is stunned. 7. The offer: his Reader's Privilege. She

refuses (Tib's fee; her wage). He says, quietly: "Have you seen weeping, Miss Vail? In keepings?" She has. He says: "So have I. Come and find out why." He leaves his card. *Clues:* quickened Hush grain in trade via Ferrers & Lisk; the gull sound; Aske knows of weeping.

Ch. 3 — Spitting Pans (2–4 Russet)

Epigraph: Lowside brine-boilers' saying: "A pan that spits is a pan that's talking. Listen before you lid her." 1. 2 Russet: Hester arrives at work. The bond-shed is empty: the cargo is gone, and the ledger page has been cut out. Mallory suspends her without pay for "insubordination and false seizure." Daisy, furious, slips her a copy of the bill of lading: consignee *Ferrers & Lisk*; shipper's mark *"W.L.F. per E.D."* (Hester doesn't know what it means. Plant.) 2. 3 Russet: the Lowside Pans. Aldous Vail at the boiling pans in steam and the smell of the Weeps. Their relationship: terse. She asks for nothing. He asks about Tib; she tells him of the weeping; he says, "Let the lad go, Hes. Eleven years." A fight, held under control. Then his pan begins to spit. He doesn't lid it; he draws the fire and lets the pan "talk" down slowly, explaining in six words. (Venting seed.) "You lid a spitting pan, she'll blow the lid through the roof." 3. That night she counts money. Without wages she has two months of Tib's fee. The Halcyon pays a Stay Choir stipend to strong holds (she has heard). The privilege covers fees. Ambry has no work for a suspended assayer. 4. 4 Russet: she goes to Aske's Ambry lodging (above a bookbinder's) and accepts. He is delighted and talks too much. He shows her the Halcyon's Entry Assay format. She asks about the weeping; he goes careful. "Not here. When you're below the Line, I'll show you. There is something wrong in the deep, and I think it's reaching up." He mentions the Matriculation on 6 Russet. 5. She goes to the Cold House one more time to tell Tib. Agathe promises to write if anything changes. *Clue:* "W.L.F. per E.D." (Warden of the Lower Fathoms, per Edwin Dunmore).

Ch. 4 — Below the Line (6 Russet)

Epigraph: Halcyon Matriculation formula: "Step over, and be below the sea." 1. Dawn. The Causeway: the White pink at sunrise, the night-chime of the tiles, the kept-light posts going out. Hester walks with a carpetbag. Plant: a figure

coming *from* Ambry at dawn: Warden Orsolya Thane in iron-grey, tired, cold-handed, with salt-mud on her boots. She greets Hester in Lowside voice ("You're Aske's privilege. Well done, chick"). Hester likes her instantly. 2. The Gatehouse: the brass Line in the floor. The Entry Assay (a formality for her; she passes with eerie ease, and the examining Reader, Crisp, notes it coldly). Stepping the Line. 3. The intake, about 110 aspirants. Teo Anselm (eating, chattering, ex-Tider). Saskia Orme (sharp, measuring Hester's darned blue). Lucan Ferrers (elegant, bored), who remarks that "Customs sends its sweepers now"; Hester replies in kind. Cell allocation: Hester with Teo in the Rookery (he asks, she agrees: "I snore." "I'll hum"). 4. The descent tour with a Proctor-guide: the Stair and the chalk-names; the Benches; the Lantern Well; the Brinestacks (a glimpse of Callow, "the furniture"); the Third Fathom Cells; the Quiet Rooms (the kept rose, the kept lightning); the Fourth Fathom Choir hall; the sealed doors to the Fifth, and below them a hum Hester feels in her teeth. 5. The Lantern Hour and the First Taste at the Long Table: kept noon light pours down the Well into the dark hall, and five dishes of grain from five Fathoms. The fifth (Fifth Fathom grain) makes nearly everyone weep salt tears. Hester tastes it and recognises the taste of the customs cargo and of Tib's beads. Quick. 6. Night in the Rookery: Teo and Hester talk; his faith story in brief; her brother mentioned, not explained. *Clues:* Orsolya on the Causeway from Ambry at dawn; Fifth-Fathom taste equals the weeping taste.

Ch. 5 — First Principles (7–15 Russet)

Epigraph: The Halcyon Primer, Law the Fourth: "What is kept is owed." 1. Crisp's Keeping class at the Pans. The hold taught as posture. Hester's hold is crude, deep and square: she keeps a falling drop of brine. Then the *return*: she can't. The drop stays kept. Crisp: "You hold like a miser, Vail." (Flaw planted.) Lucan's hold is precise and shallow. Saskia's is fluid. 2. Sorle's Horology lecture in the Black Bench. He is acid, brilliant and cruel. He teaches the Law of Arrears with the arrears calculus on a slate and humiliates Lucan. He teaches *still runs to quick* with a demonstration: two keepings joined by a brine thread, where one weeps into the other. The beads run *in lines toward the quicker*. (Clue: Hester recognises Tib's weeping pattern. Draw-weeping.) Students mutter "Sorle's Folly."

He says the sea is "not gone, only paused" as a provocation, and is laughed at. 3. Montage of days: Bassano's Lumen (light kept in jars); the Brinestacks; the aching cold; the thirst; Teo baking contraband saltcake. Saskia snipes at Hester ("charity case") and Hester snipes back ("rent collector"). 4. 15 Russet: Hester meets Aske in his Cell 3-17. He shows her a crystal from a Fifth-Fathom stay that holds a live bead *beating* slowly, like a pulse. "The deep is quickening. They're staying it as fast as they can, and something is making the stays easier than they should be." He's agitated. "Come tomorrow night at the tenth bell. I'll have it all laid out. Bring your tongue." He hums, distracted, writing in his shorthand. 5. She walks back up the Stair and passes Sorle coming down. They exchange no words. *Clue:* draw-weeping pattern (Ch. 1 ₅ Ch. 5); stays "easier than they should be."

Ch. 6 — Kept (16–17 Russet)

Epigraph: The Stillborn Clause, Charter of the Grain, §41: "A person kept beyond hope of return shall be accounted dead in law." 1. 16 Russet, tenth bell. Hester at Cell 3-17. Locked; dark; no answer. She waits a half-hour in the cold corridor. She hears footsteps on the Stair below, someone *coming up from the Fourth/Fifth*, heavy, dragging something on a trolley (she assumes a porter with brine casks). She leaves, annoyed. 2. 17 Russet, dawn. Uproar on the Third Fathom. Aske was found by a porter at first bell: kept, standing, in a casing in his Cell, one arm reaching, mouth open mid-word. 3. Hester pushes through. Chief Proctor Gage presides. The verdict-in-advance: a self-keeping experiment (Aske was notorious for testing on himself). Hush grain was found in a basin. "Kept beyond return: Hush arrears would kill him. In law, dead." 4. Hester observes as an assayer: - The casing's grain is wrong for a self-keeping. Self-keepings grow outward from the worker's skin, and this one grew *inward* from outside, poured. - The grain shows a fine spiral, turning widdershins. She notes it and doesn't understand it. - The casing is clear, not grey. She remembers Agathe: "the living keep clear." Gage: "Hush grain keeps everything clear." She has no reason to doubt him. - She sneaks a tongue-touch on the casing's foot. The taste is Hush grain, the cargo's taste. - His notebooks are gone; only a loose sheet is left in the blotter, in shorthand. - She pockets the sheet. (A transgres-

sion: she withholds evidence.) 5. Gage questions her. She was at the door last night, and the porter saw her. Suspicion falls on her, and she shows a bristling innocence. Sorle is questioned too; he was on the Third Fathom at the tenth bell. Lucan is mentioned: he argued with Aske the day before. 6. Orsolya arrives, kind and grieving: "Corvin. Oh, you daft man." She puts a cold hand on Hester's shoulder. "You're without a Bench now, chick. Come and see me." 7. The Registrar: without a sponsor by the Midwinter Assay, she'll be sent down. *Ends:* in the Rookery, Hester unfolds the sheet, which she can't read; Teo looks over her shoulder: "That's brine-script shorthand. I can read that." *Clues:* inward-poured casing; widdershins spiral; clear casing; the heavy trolley on the Stair from below (Aske carried up).

Ch. 7 — Ask O. (17–19 Russet)

Epigraph: a Tider hymn: "Ask, and the tide shall answer; ask not, and the tide shall still answer." 1. Teo deciphers: *"Cold House — 14 weeping. Harl St Brinery — 0. Varenne Private — 0. Charity only? A draw? Still runs to quick. Cistern?? Old lines. Ask O."* 2. Discussion: Hester decides she will find out. She tells Teo about Tib properly (the keeping, the fee; not the wish). 3. Who is O? Teo: the Order? Hester: Orme? (Saskia is Aske's courier for Bassano's light samples, a convenient suspicion.) Orsolya isn't raised; it doesn't occur to her. 4. Hester confronts Lucan about his argument with Aske, in the Brinestacks Reading Well. Lucan, cold: Aske accused his father's firm of buying deep grain. "My father buys what the Halcyon sells him. Ask *your* Halcyon." She mentions the *Constant Wren*. Lucan doesn't know of it. A flicker. 5. Aske's casing is moved to the Quiet Rooms. Hester watches the porters, and Orsolya directs them gently. Hester stays a minute by the casing. 6. Saskia appears to have been crying (Hester misreads it). Saskia snaps. *Ends:* Hester lists suspects in her ledger like a customs schedule.

Ch. 8 — The Stay Choir (20–23 Russet)

Epigraph: Stay Choir work-song, refrain: "Hold the line, hold the line, so the others can sleep." 1. The sponsor hunt. Crisp refuses honestly ("I'm full and you're unfinished"). Bassano is kind but full. Two Readers refuse for class reas-

ons. Sorle refuses insultingly ("I don't take charity cases from the dead"). 2. Orsolya's office in the Fifth-Fathom antechamber (the Warden's Gallery). Warmth, tea, Lowside talk; Orsolya's dead father, a delver crushed at Coldbank. She can't formally sponsor until her current aspirants assay out, but she offers a Choir place: "I need holds like yours." Stipend: 3 sols a week. Hester accepts (money for Tib). - Plant: Orsolya says, tired, "The Stays have been kind this season. Kinder than they've any right to be." (Unreadable to Hester at this point.) - The clerk Dunmore: bland and efficient. 3. First descent with the Choir. Sixty workers in grey wool; the slow singing to lock breath; descending into the Fifth Fathom's galleries; brass stay-lines; the warm wet salt of a quickening. 4. The stay. Hester holds with the Choir and her stillness flows into the line. In the hold she hears it, through her teeth: the sea. Waves. Wind. A roar with *shape*. She weeps salt and doesn't know why. 5. After: lag, cold, the thirst. Ama Tessaly, a Choir elder, wraps her in a blanket. Orsolya is proud. *Clue:* "the stays have been kind"; the stay-lines run east (a passing detail: "the eastern trunk").

Ch. 9 — The Brinestacks (24–27 Russet)

Epigraph: Brinestacks notice: "Readers are reminded that the tablets remember being touched." 1. Hester and Teo research in the Brinestacks. They look for the Cold House's records in the Exchequer's brinery returns: three charity sleepers "returned by casing failure" and died in the past ten months. Normal rate: one in three years. 2. "Cistern" in the catalogue. The founders'-era Cistern plans were requested on 2 Russet by C. Aske, and before him, a year ago, by "W.L.F. (office)." Hester doesn't decode W.L.F. She connects it to "W.L.F. per E.D." on the bill of lading. Something to find out. (She asks a clerk, who is out; the lead hangs.) 3. The plans: the Great Cistern beneath Coldwater Street, and a main line running east under the White *to the Halcyon*. Teo: "The Cold House is sitting on the old reservoir." 4. Teo reads an old Brinescript tablet (230 Y.E., prefire) and in the Roar beneath it hears a falling cry. Hester: "That. I heard that in the cargo." Teo, astonished, finds it in a hymnal woodcut caption: *"the gull, a bird of the sea, crying."* "Hester. There are no gulls." 5. Wynn Callow, "the furniture," speaks one sentence as they leave: "Corvin sat there too. On the first of

the month." (Aske came to read the same.) *Clues:* the W.L.F. requisition; the Cistern route; the gull.

Ch. 10 — Lantern Night (30 Russet)

Epigraph: Ambry street-song: "Summer in a jar, summer in a jar, pour it on the rooftops where the cold folk are." 1. Afternoon: Hester, Teo and Saskia in Ambry. Saskia is warmer outside the Halcyon. They go to the Glassmarket: Saskia's mother Hennie and daughter Pip. Saskia's husband drowned in a sink. A turn in their relationship. 2. Saskia explains annealing while they watch the lantern-jars being loaded for the release: "Glass that cools fast keeps its stress inside and one day it just bursts. You cool it slow and the stress walks out." (Venting seed #2.) 3. The Cold House at dusk. Tib's casing weeps more. Agathe shows them a sleeper, Bett Linnow, whose casing is thinning badly. Agathe is frightened. Lucan Ferrers is in the ward, in an expensive coat, looking at the casings and the eastern floor drains. A confrontation in whispers. He admits he came because of the *Constant Wren*: he asked his father, who told him to drop it. He saw the Cold House's name on a Ferrers supply invoice, for brine delivered "for cistern maintenance." Grudging truce. 4. Lantern Night itself. At the ninth bell the Halcyon pours a summer's kept light over Ambry from jars on the rooftops and the Lantern. The city is lit gold; birdsong of the summer days is in it; the warmth on the face; people cry and laugh. Hester stands with Teo, Saskia, Pip on Saskia's hip, and Lucan a few feet off. Beauty. 5. Lucan, quietly, at the end: "I don't think it was an accident." Hester: "No." *Clues:* annealing; the "cistern maintenance" invoice; Bett Linnow failing.

Ch. 11 — The Sink (6 Fallow)

Epigraph: Weathering field manual: "The White does not forgive. The White does not hate. The White is a floor with a hole in it." 1. Fathoming field practical: Orsolya leads twenty first-years by landship (the skiff *Gannet*) to a surface "bloom-site" 5 miles out: a quickening near the surface on the open White. Sailing the White: speed, wind, runners hissing, glare-goggles, the Pull. Hester has never sailed. Exhilaration. 2. The bloom-site: wet salt, warm, a smell of weed, and a faint sound of surf from underfoot. 3. Plant: Orsolya, chatting with

Hester: "How's your brother? Still at the Cold House? Coldwater Street. They're good there." Hester never told her the street, or even the brinery. Hester thinks Aske must have told her. 4. The sink opens. Lucan falls. Hester throws her brine-flask across him as he drops and keeps him: a man-shaped casing hanging in the rim of the sink, one hand up. Then she has to return him before the casing's weight drags it down. She can't release. Orsolya talks her through it ("Don't push it out, chick. Open your hand"). She returns him; the arrears snap cracks two of his ribs; he lives. 5. Hester lags for four minutes. She comes to on the salt with the sky changed, the others around her, Teo holding her hand. Terror at lost time. 6. Back at the Halcyon, Sorle appears at the Rookery door. "You kept a man. Badly. Interesting. My study, Thursday." *Clues:* Orsolya knows the Cold House street. The release flaw is shown.

Ch. 12 — Sorle's Folly (8–9 Fallow)

Epigraph: Minutes of the Conclave, 871 Y.E.: "Reader Sorle's hypothesis was found to be without foundation and an embarrassment to the Bench." 1. Sorle's study: books, slates, a kept moth on his desk, his dead wife's portrait. He interrogates her keeping of Lucan, then Aske. 2. Sorle admits he was invited to Aske's Cell on 16 Russet at the tenth-and-a-half bell (half an hour after her). He arrived and found the corridor empty, saw nothing, and left. He believes Aske was killed. "Corvin couldn't keep himself in a pickle jar. His hold was *radial*. A child could see that casing was poured." 3. The Held Moment Hypothesis, explained by Sorle as Hester's teacher: the sea is not gone but held, and grain is its stillness. Hester thinks it's mad; she can't dismiss the gull. Sorle on 871: "I was demolished by a young Fathomer with a gift for sums. Orsolya Thane. She was right about my maths and wrong about the world." 4. He won't sponsor her yet: "Bring me evidence. Not tastes. Evidence I can put on a slate." 5. Lucan in the Physic ward with cracked ribs. He thanks her badly; she accepts badly. A small honesty: he has never owed anyone anything. Begins. *Ends:* Hester resolves to go into the Cistern.

Ch. 13 — The Cistern (14 Fallow) — MIDPOINT

Epigraph: Ambry Water Board, 400 Y.E.: "The founders' cistern is bricked and shall not be reopened." 1. Planning with Teo and Lucan. Lucan supplies Exchequer plans and money. Agathe lets them in through the Cold House cellar at night (Pell is away). 2. The descent: old brick, founders' brass, a vaulted reservoir (the Great Cistern) dry but for a channel of live brine. The smell is quick. 3. They find the draw: new brass rods with Halcyon Lattice-mason marks, sleeved in live brine, running from drains under the charity ward's eastern floor into the founders' main line *east*. Hester tastes the brine in the line: it is stiller than anything she has ever tasted. "This is them. This is Tib." 4. Teo reads the line: the Roar, and under it *children breathing*. The sleepers' moments, flowing. 5. Pell surprises them with a lamp and a cudgel, terrified. A struggle. Lucan's name stops him ("I am Lucan Ferrers. Put that down"). Pell blurts out "the Halcyon's maintenance," the "gentleman from the Warden's office," "ten sols a month." They escape with one draw-rod sawn free. 6. Outside at dawn: the realisation. The draw runs to the Halcyon. Someone inside is drawing stillness from the sleepers. "Warden's office": which Warden? There are four. *Midpoint reversal:* not smuggling but a draw from inside.

Ch. 14 — What Is Owed (15–20 Fallow)

Epigraph: Sorle, *Lectures on Arrears*: "Every keeping is a lie we tell time, and time collects." 1. Hester takes the rod to Chief Proctor Gage, against Sorle's advice. He listens and is grave. He takes the rod and promises inquiry. 2. Two days later the rod is "lost." Gage warns her off: "There are matters of Halcyon infrastructure above both our heads." She suspects Gage and wonders whom he answers to. (Deputy Chancellor Vey is glimpsed leaving Gage's office.) 3. Hester goes to Sorle with the full account: the rod lost, Pell's words. Sorle believes her. He sponsors her: "I have nothing left to lose and you have even less. That's a Bench." He gives her his black cord. A key emotional turn. 4. Lessons with Sorle: the arrears calculus; quickenings as moments under pressure; still runs to quick. "Stays saturate. Pour enough still into a quickening and it quiets — and grows hungrier." Hester asks: "What if you let it out?" Sorle: "Then the moment

proceeds." He refuses the thought as madness for now. (Venting seed #3.) 5. Hester writes to Agathe and gets a reply: Tib's weeping is worse, Bett is worse.

Ch. 15 — Ferrers (22–28 Fallow)

Epigraph: a Ferrers & Lisk contract clause: "The purchaser shall make no enquiry as to provenance." 1. Lucan has gone to his father's house in the Upper Ward and found the contract: Ferrers & Lisk buys "residual stay grain" from W.L.F. (the office of the Warden of the Lower Fathoms), signed by E. Dunmore, clerk. His father told him to stay out of it ("the Halcyon's dirty laundry keeps our lamps lit"). Lucan tells Hester; he is shaken. 2. Hester decodes W.L.F. at last: the Warden of the Lower Fathoms. Orsolya's office. She refuses the conclusion. *Dunmore*. The clerk. Orsolya can't know: she's Lowside; she's the Choir's mother. Hester reasons it's Dunmore, perhaps for Vey. (Self-deception shown.) 3. Orsolya's private lessons in the hold (she has offered to help Hester's release). Warmth, and Orsolya's story of Coldbank. Plant: Orsolya demonstrates keeping a candle flame and the casing shows a widdershins spiral. "Every worker leaves a hand, chick. Mine's a corkscrew. My mam said I came out twisting." Hester sees it. Something tugs; she doesn't let it surface. 4. Hester sounds Orsolya out about Dunmore. Orsolya, smooth: "Edwin handles the residue contracts; it's all above board, Conclave-approved." Hester is relieved and not quite relieved. 5. Choir shift: the stays still draw easier than they should.

Ch. 16 — Annealing (2–4 Cinder)

Epigraph: a Quell glassmakers' proverb: "Glass remembers how it cooled." 1. Saskia is short of money. Hester, ledger-minded, notices her new boots and her late returns. 2. Saskia confesses after Hester confronts her in the Lumen kilns. Since summer she has been doing evening courier work for "the Warden's clerk": carrying sealed grain boxes from the Fifth-Fathom lift to the Ferrers landship at the dry harbour, 2 sols a run. She carried the *Constant Wren* boxes. "I didn't ask. I've a daughter. I don't do causes, Vail. I do rent." 3. A real fight: ugly, adult, both right. 4. Reconciliation (later, in the Rookery with Teo's saltcake). Saskia offers what she knows: the boxes came up from the Fifth; Dunmore was always the hand; she never saw the Warden. She also mentions that Dun-

more keeps the Warden's duplicate keys in his desk, including the Hush key. (Plant for the Act III key.) 5. Hester tells Saskia everything. The group of four (Hester, Teo, Saskia, Lucan) forms. *Clue:* "O." might be Orme? Hester rules it out now. Reader suspicion is redirected.

Ch. 17 — The Silent Supper (9 Cinder)

Epigraph: Halcyon custom: "For one minute the whole Halcyon is still, and the Settled are named." 1. The Silent Supper: the names on the Stair re-chalked by candle. The Minute: six hundred people utterly still at the Long Table, and Hester can feel the whole Halcyon holding. 2. The alarm bell in the middle of the Minute. A quickening has broken in the Fourth Fathom's east gallery, *above* the Stays. Water is running out of salt. 3. The Choir goes down. Chaos and beauty: seawater (cold, smelling of weed) running across the gallery floor, archives in danger, the sound of surf in the walls. 4. The stay. Orsolya leads, magnificent. Hester holds in the Choir line. Mid-hold she feels stillness arriving through the stay-line from the east, not from the Choir: a cold, old, vast stillness. *She knows its taste. It is the taste of the line under the Cold House. It is the taste of Tib.* The stays are fed by the sleepers. 5. Ama Tessaly holds too long and Settles to death on the gallery floor, still sitting, still singing. 6. After: Orsolya kneels by Ama and weeps. Hester watches her, and *cannot* make herself think what she has to think. "The stays have been kind this season." *Ends:* Hester goes up the Stair and chalks Ama's name.

Ch. 18 — The Fourth Sleeper (16–18 Cinder) — DARK MOMENT

Epigraph: from a Brinery release form: "Signature of next of kin. Relationship. Date. The house accepts no responsibility for what returns." 1. Agathe sends for her. Bett Linnow is coming back: the casing is failing beyond recasting. Hester goes. Bett's mother Ruth, 79, holds her hand. Bett returns, gasping in the last instant of her twenty-year-old haemorrhage, and dies in the arrears-heat. Unbearable. 2. Tib's casing: thin at the eastern foot. Agathe: "Weeks, chick. Not months." 3. Hester goes to Aldous drunk-adjacent and tells him. He says that as next of kin he'll sign Tib's release himself, now, "before he goes like that lass." The worst fight of their lives. He says the thing: "You didn't keep him for him.

You kept him for you." She leaves. 4. The Rookery. Teo. She tells him the truth: "He asked me to let him sleep. He knew what he meant. I signed." The confession: eleven years of it. Teo does not absolve her. He sits with her. "Then you've been keeping two people, Hes. Him and the girl who signed." 5. Low point: she considers stealing Hush grain to recast Tib herself. She doesn't. Barely.

Ch. 19 — The Notebook (25–28 Cinder)

Epigraph: Wynn Callow's only published sentence, 851 Y.E.: "The archive is a keeping like any other, and like any other it is owed." 1. Callow's hint returns to her: "Corvin sat there too." Hester sits at Callow's desk for an afternoon. Callow speaks in his slowness: Aske filed something "where the founders sleep." In the Founders' Gallery, behind a catalogue drawer of 230 Y.E. fire-salvage, they find Aske's notebooks. 2. Teo deciphers through the night. Aske traced it all: the quickened grain in trade; the Cold House draw; the founders' Cistern line to the Old Tap in the Fifth; W.L.F.; Dunmore; Pell. His last entry (15 Russet): *"She is right that it will flood. She is wrong that it must be held. The pressure wants a road, not a lid. Vent? Need Sorle's arrears for the shaft. I'll ask O. tomorrow, before I tell Gage. I owe her that. — If anything — tell Hester to taste it."* 3. Hester returns alone to the Quiet Rooms and tastes Aske's casing again, reading it now with full knowledge. The hand is a widdershins spiral. Orsolya's corkscrew. 4. And the clearness. She asks Callow. He takes a long time: "Hush grain keeps clear quickly. Then it blooms like any other. A month. Corvin's been there two." Aske's casing is still clear. Aske is alive. Kept, not killed. 5. Hester sits in the Quiet Room with the truth. Orsolya. And Aske alive.

Ch. 20 — The Warden (2 Rime)

Epigraph: Orsolya Thane, Stay Choir address, 899 Y.E.: "I have buried eleven of mine. I'll not bury more." 1. Against everyone's advice in advance (she tells no one; her flaw), Hester goes to Orsolya's office at night. 2. The confrontation: the spiral; the notebook; Dunmore; the draw. 3. Orsolya confesses. - Quickenings have tripled since 896. Eleven choristers buried in five years; Ama makes twelve. - The Chancellor and Vey told her to manage quietly and gave her nothing: "no inquiry, no money, no noise." - If the Hush breaches, the Halcyon floods, and

perhaps the crust between here and Ambry with it. - She found the founders' lines. "They built the Cistern for this, chick. The founders. To feed the stays. It was always meant." (A saga hint.) - The sleepers: "Their families are bled white for keeping. They're gone, Hester. We keep them because we can't bear the bill of letting go. I'm letting them go *usefully*." - Aske: he tried to shut the Old Tap and the line would have backflowed into the stays. "I kept him, God help me, I didn't kill him. I kept him till it's over. I'll vent him myself when we're through." 4. The offer: "Your lad's line — I can route round him. He'll hold till spring and past. Nobody need know." Hester says nothing. 5. Orsolya lets her go: "Think about it. You're Lowside. You know what it is to choose who drowns." 6. Next day, a note from Agathe: Tib's casing has stopped weeping. *Orsolya did it without being asked.* Hester's complicity. *Ends:* Hester sits on the Stair below Ama's chalked name.

Ch. 21 — Still Runs to Quick (3–19 Rime)

Epigraph: Halcyon Primer, Law the Fifth: "Still runs to quick." 1. Hester tells the four and Sorle everything, including the offer and the fact that Tib is now safe *because of* Orsolya. Debate: - Go to the Chancellor? (Sorle: the Seal will bury it; Gage already lost the rod.) - Go to the Assize? (The Halcyon will close ranks, the draw will continue, and the Hush will still be failing.) - Cut the draw? (The Hush breaches and kills thousands.) 2. Hester's turn: refusing the binary. "The pressure wants a road, not a lid." Aske's notes, her father's pans, Saskia's annealing, Sorle's arrears. 3. Sorle works the calculus over four days on every slate in his study. Venting is possible *if* the pressure has a road to somewhere harmless, and if the release is paced (Saskia: "annealed") over hours, in stages. The Founders' Shaft runs from the Hush to the open White. Let the sea come up it. 4. The cost: the moment *proceeds*. What's held in that pocket will move. Water on the White. And the founders' records in the Fourth Fathom's east gallery may flood. Sorle: "If I am right about the sea, we are about to find out in public." 5. The plan for Assay Night: - after the Assay, the whole Halcyon feasts and the lower Fathoms are emptiest; - Lucan and Teo cut the draw in the Cistern with Agathe's help; - Saskia steals the Hush key from Dunmore's desk; - Hester, Saskia and Sorle open the Hush and the Founders' Shaft and vent. - Hester must

be the release, the thing she can't do. 6. Hester visits Aldous and they don't reconcile. She asks him how to let a pan down slow and he tells her, in detail, the whole craft. Unspoken things. 7. Training the release with Sorle and Orsolya's own technique ("Open your hand").

Ch. 22 — The Midwinter Assay (21 Rime)

Epigraph: the Assay formula: "Discern. Keep. Return." 1. The Hall of Assay: the salt chandeliers lit, the galleries full of Ambry. Aldous is *there*, at the back, in a clean coat. (He came.) 2. Teo's Assay: brilliant discernment, a wobbly keep, and "Assayed." Saskia's: "Assayed with distinction." Lucan's: "Assayed with distinction." 3. Hester's Assay before Crisp, Bassano, Vey, Orsolya and Chancellor Holm (frail, motionless). - Discernment: perfect. She also names a sample as "quickened Hush, from the Fifth, east gallery" and sees Orsolya's face. - Keeping: a moth in flight. - Return: she must release the moth, and she does: she opens her hand. The moth flies. Crisp: "With distinction." 4. Orsolya's eyes meet hers across the hall. Orsolya knows that Hester has decided. Neither moves. 5. The Assay Night feast begins. The four slip away.

Ch. 23 — The Old Tap (21 Rime, night)

Epigraph: Lowside saying: "Take her off the heat slow." 1. Interleaved through Hester's knowledge and timing, never leaving her POV: - Saskia gets the key. - Hester and Sorle descend through the empty Fifth to the Hush door. - At the agreed bell, the cut: Hester feels it happen as a change in the stay-line's taste. The sleepers' stillness stops arriving. 2. The Hush: the founders' working floor, humming, with ancient brass and a vast smooth floor of clear deep salt. Under it, something dark and enormous. (Not explained; saga.) 3. The quickening at the Hush's east end is already warm, wet and loud with surf. With the draw cut, it surges at once. 4. They find the Founders' Shaft and dissolve its salt plug with hot brine and crowbars. It's harder than planned. Sorle is old. 5. Alarms above. The skeleton Choir is called. Orsolya is coming.

Ch. 24 — The Hush (21–22 Rime, night) — CLIMAX

Epigraph: none, or the founders' motto: "What is kept is not lost." 1. Orsolya arrives with Dunmore and two Fathomers. Confrontation in the roaring dark: "You've killed us all, chick." 2. The quickening breaches. Seawater bursts from the salt, black and cold and alive with the smell of weed. 3. The vent: Hester at the boundary, in brine to her knees, hands on the quickening's skin of salt. She has to *release*: give the moment its road up the shaft. She can't. She holds, her flaw, and the pressure climbs. 4. Orsolya sees the shaft taking water and understands that the vent could work. Her choice: she orders the Fathomers and Dunmore to hold the gallery stays above, keeping the Fifth from flooding. Dunmore flees. She holds alone with her two Fathomers. 5. Hester's release. She thinks of Tib: "let me sleep." She thinks of her father's hands drawing the fire. *Open your hand*. She lets go. 6. Saskia counts the stages: "Hold. Now. Hold. Now." Sorle times the arrears on a slate by lantern. 7. The sea goes up the shaft in pulses, roaring. 8. Hester's release-cost: the rush (heat, a racing heart, time flaring). She nearly dies. Sorle holds her. 9. Silence. The quickening is spent. The Hush hums lower. *Ends:* Orsolya sitting on the Fifth-Fathom floor, Settled for hours, her hands open.

Ch. 25 — The Gull (22–28 Rime)

Epigraph: a Rim ballad: "And the grey birds cried over Ostrine water / where no grey bird has cried since." 1. Dawn. Hester is carried up. A quarter-mile east of the Lantern, where the Well-Cap was, a lake steams in the frost: black water on the white salt, its edges already freezing. Half the Halcyon is on the shore, and Ambry's people are coming over the Causeway. 2. In the shallows: weed, green and living; small silver fish moving; a crab. 3. The gull: a grey-and-white bird struggling out of the water onto the ice, shaking, and then crying, *the sound*, and lifting, and flying over the White toward Ambry. The first in nine centuries. 4. Chancellor Holm stands at the Lantern's foot and watches it. Hester sees her face: grief, not surprise. Holm: "It was always going to come back, Miss Vail. We only hoped to be dead first." (Ambiguous.) 5. Consequences in quick, adult strokes: - Orsolya confesses to Gage and is arrested; - Pell is arrested in the city; - Dunmore has fled; - the Ferrers contract is leaked by Lucan to the Assize; - Vey's

statement calls it "a natural quickening event"; - the Fourth Fathom's east archive is flooded; - the Cold House sleepers are secure. 6. Aske's return. Hester and Sorle, with Physic, vent Aske's casing over six days in a warm bath, in stages, annealed. - On the sixth day his hand moves. He wakes mid-sentence: "—you can't, Orsolya, it'll backflow—" Then, blinking at Hester: "Oh. You tasted it." Then: "How long?" "Three months." "Have I missed the Assay?" "You have." "Did you pass?" - His right hand is stiff (partial Settle) and permanent.

Ch. 26 — What the Salt Keeps (29–30 Rime)

Epigraph: The Halcyon motto: "What is kept is not lost." 1. Hester visits Orsolya in the Proctory cells. Two Lowside women. No forgiveness, but understanding. Orsolya: "Did it hurt? Letting go?" "Yes." "Good. Means you did it right." 2. The Cold House. Tib's casing is clear and dry. Aldous comes with her: his first visit in nine years, at the door, unable, then able. He touches the casing. Hester tells Tib the truth aloud, the whole thing, with her father listening. Her promise: "When I know how to bring you back properly, or when I know how to let you go, I'll do it. For you. Not for me. And I'll tell you first." Agathe's line returns: "The living keep clear." 3. Sorle formally enters her on his Bench as an Assayed aspirant. Lucan, ribs healed, and Hester: one moment of charged honesty, unresolved, adult. ("I find I don't mind owing you." "That's a start.") 4. The Ebbtide Vigil (night of 30 Rime). The Tiders walk out onto the White with candles to "meet the tide," and *this year there is water*. The whole city walks, a river of candles on the salt to the new lake. Teo in his old Tider shawl. Saskia with Pip. Lucan. Aldous walks a little way. 5. At the water's edge Hester and Teo kneel. The new crust forming at the shore. Teo reads it; Hester tastes it (the sea, tears, something living). Teo goes still and says: "There's someone." A voice in the salt, human, one word, a question: *Aelith?* Neither knows the language. 6. Final image: Hester looks out over the black water toward the Deep, the first real sea-wind of nine hundred years in her face, and doesn't know the answer, and finds she can bear not knowing. Close.

Mystery clue map (Book One)

Truth	Clue	Chapter (plant)	Payoff
A draw pulls stillness from the sleepers	Weeping runs in lines toward the east foot; it tastes quick	1	5 (Sorle's demo), 13 (rods)
Hush grain is leaving the Halcyon	The *Constant Wren* cargo	2	15, 16
W.L.F. is the Warden of the Lower Fathoms	"W.L.F. per E.D." on the bill; the Cistern requisition	3, 9	15
E.D. is Edwin Dunmore	Dunmore introduced as clerk	8	15
Orsolya visits the Cistern	Seen on the Causeway from Ambry at dawn with mud on her boots	4	20
The stays are fed	"The stays are easier than they should be" (Aske); "the stays have been kind" (Orsolya); the eastern trunk	5, 8	17
Orsolya knows the Cold House	She names Coldwater Street	11	19/20
Aske's casing was poured, not self-made	Inward growth	6	12 (Sorle confirms), 19
Orsolya's hand	Widdershins spiral in Aske's casing; Orsolya's corkscrew demo	6, 15	19
Aske is alive	The casing stays clear; "the living keep clear"; Hush blooms within a month	1, 6	19, 25
Aske was carried up		6	20

Truth	Clue	Chapter (plant)	Payoff
	A heavy trolley on the Stair from below at the tenth bell		
The sea is alive and held	The gull sound; the Roar with shape; weed smell living; "the sea paused"	2, 8, 9, 5	24, 25
Venting works	Pans (3), annealing (10), "let it out" (14), Aske's notes (19)	—	21, 24
Saskia's courier work	New boots; crying (misread); late returns	7, 15, 16	16

Red herrings: - Lucan: the argument with Aske; his father's firm. He is innocent of the crime; his family is guilty of complicity. - Sorle: present on the Third Fathom at the tenth-and-a-half bell; old rivalry. Innocent. - Saskia: "O. = Orme"; courier work. Guilty of small complicity. - Gage / Vey: the lost rod. Guilty of a cover-up of *infrastructure*, not of the death; protecting the Seal's secrecy.

Timeline (903 Y.E.)

Date	Event	Ch.
1 Russet	Cold House; cargo; Aske	1–2
2 Russet	Cargo gone; suspended	3
3 Russet	Aldous	3
4 Russet	Accepts	3
6 Russet	Matriculation	4
7–15 Russet	First classes; Aske's crystal	5
16 Russet, 10th bell	Aske kept by Orsolya at the Old Tap; carried to 3-17	6 (offstage)
17 Russet	Aske found	6
17–19 Russet	Ask O.; casing moved	7
20–23 Russet	Sponsor hunt; Choir	8

Date	Event	Ch.
24–27 Russet	Brinestacks	9
30 Russet	Lantern Night	10
6 Fallow	Sink	11
8–9 Fallow	Sorle	12
14 Fallow	Cistern	13
15–20 Fallow	Gage; Sorle sponsors	14
22–28 Fallow	Ferrers contract; spiral lesson	15
2–4 Cinder	Saskia	16
9 Cinder	Silent Supper; Ama dies	17
16–18 Cinder	Bett dies; Aldous; confession	18
25–28 Cinder	Notebook; spiral; Aske alive	19
2 Rime	Orsolya confesses	20
3 Rime	Tib's weeping stops	20
3–19 Rime	Plan	21
21 Rime	Assay; vent	22–24
22 Rime	Lake; gull	25
22–28 Rime	Aske vented; wakes on 28	25
29–30 Rime	Orsolya; Cold House; Vigil; *Aelith*	26

Worldbuilding dependency map

[A]Ch. 1 needs: casings, fees, the clear/grey rule, the Tider faith.

[A]Ch. 2 needs: landships, grades, the Charter felony, reading.

[A]Ch. 4 needs: the Halcyon's geography, the Line, the First Taste.

[A]Ch. 5 needs: the Laws (1–5), the hold and release, arrears, Bench rules.

[A]Ch. 8 needs: stays, the Choir, quickenings.

[A]Ch. 11 needs: sinks, landships, lag, keeping a person.

[A]Ch. 13 needs: the Cistern history.

[A]Ch. 17 needs: the Silent Supper tradition, the Settle.

[A]Ch. 21–24 need: venting assembled from four seeds; the Founders' Shaft (introduced Ch. 4 tour as a capped well on the White "never opened"; mentioned Ch. 21).

[A]Ch. 25 needs: the gull (Ch. 2, 9).

Climactic payoff structure

1. Plot: the draw cut + the vent = the sleepers saved and the Halcyon saved.
2. Mystery: Aske returned and testifying; Orsolya's confession; Dunmore/Pell/Ferrers exposed.
3. Character: Hester's release (the flaw overcome in action, not speech). Orsolya's right choice. Saskia's loyalty (the key). Lucan defies his father (the cut). Teo listens (*Aelith*). Sorle vindicated privately.
4. Theme: keeping is not loving; let it move.
5. Saga: living water; a gull; a voice.

Five Original Series Concepts — Development & Evaluation

Each concept covers: premise; academy; protagonist; magical mechanism; emotional foundation; principal conflict; central mystery; wider civilisation; seven-book potential; ultimate resolution.

Concept A — THE HALCYON (salt that keeps time)

Premise. Nine hundred years ago an inland sea vanished in a single night and left behind a white plain of salt three hundred miles across. Salt from that plain does something no other salt does. Crystallising around a thing, it holds the thing *still* in time: the instant is preserved, readable, and can be returned. A whole civilisation now runs on mining, licensing and spending that salt.

Academy. The Halcyon is a university carved downward into a salt dome on the old seabed. Its levels are measured in *fathoms*: depth below the vanished waterline. It is a university, a regulator and a licensing monopoly all at once. It trains the physicians who "keep" the dying until cures exist, the assayers who certify salt, the archivists who read history out of crystal, and the glaziers who sell bottled daylight.

Protagonist. Hester Vail, 33, a customs-house assayer from the brine-boiling district. Eleven years ago she had her dying fourteen-year-old brother *kept* in a salt casing, against his own whispered wish. She has paid for his keeping ever since.

Mechanism. Three operations: Keep, Read, Return. The worker lends their own bodily stillness to the salt as its template. The universal cost is *arrears*: everything kept accrues pressure to resume, and that pressure must be paid somewhere.

Emotional foundation. Grief, and the difference between keeping and loving. Holding on versus letting go, played out at three scales: a sister, an institution, a civilisation.

Principal conflict. Book One: the city's kept sleepers are "weeping," and their casings are failing. A Reader who noticed is found dead, kept in salt. Saga: the economy of the whole world consumes something it does not understand.

Central mystery. What is the Hollow Sea? *Truth:* the sea did not vanish. It was *kept*, stilled in one instant by the Halcyon's founders, and the people living in it were stilled too. Every grain mined and dissolved spends a little of their held moment. The founders stilled the sea to stop a war they were losing. They then wrote themselves into history as survivors of a natural disaster.

Civilisation. The Rim states around the salt plain; salt trade; the Exchequer; the Ebb faith, which prophesies the sea's return; a rival academy across the plain; nomadic salt-walkers; the mountain kingdoms that buy kept medicine.

Seven-book potential. Very high. It escalates from a city mystery, to political economy, to an expedition across the salt, to first contact with the held moment, to war, to a partial release, to the final reckoning.

Ultimate resolution. The world chooses to *return* the sea, slowly, over a generation. It accepts the end of salt magic as it is known, and the restoration of a people it erased. Hester completes the long return. She also lets her brother go: his keeping is finally *returned*, not recast.

Concept B — THE ECHO CONSERVATORY

Premise. Every sound ever made persists, faintly, in stone. In a few canyons of perfect acoustics the dead can still be heard. Echo-scholars retrieve historical speech. They can also *re-voice* echoes so that the sounded event partly repeats. The echo of a bridge collapsing can collapse a bridge.

Academy. The Conservatory is cut into the walls of the Choral Gorge, with listening galleries, silence vaults and a "dead room" where nothing echoes.

Protagonist. A 40-year-old court stenographer who is going deaf.

Mechanism. Retrieval and re-voicing of persisted sound. The cost is that the scholar's own voice gradually fails to persist: they become unrecorded, unremembered.

Emotional foundation. Testimony, being heard, the ethics of recording the dead.

Conflict / mystery. An echo is found of a voice that has not spoken yet.

Civilisation. A legal culture built on echo-testimony.

Seven-book potential. Good, but the future-voice mystery tends toward a time-loop plot, which narrows it.

Resolution. The future voice is the protagonist's own last act.

Concept C — THE POSTAL COLLEGIUM OF TRUE ADDRESS

Premise. Anything with a true address can be reached, by letter, by object, by person. Magic is the discovery and forgery of addresses. The imperial postal service is the most powerful institution on the continent.

Academy. A collegium for postmasters-arcane, built around an infinite sorting hall.

Protagonist. A 29-year-old dead-letter clerk who reads undeliverable mail.

Mechanism. Addresses as fundamental units of location-identity. The cost is that the worker loses their own address and becomes progressively harder to find, even by friends.

Emotional foundation. Connection, loneliness, the people the system loses.

Conflict / mystery. Letters are arriving addressed to places that do not exist.

Seven-book potential. Good. Whimsical, but risks feeling like a single clever idea stretched across seven books.

Resolution. The non-existent places are the erased provinces of a war the empire forgot.

Concept D — THE SECOND LAMP

Premise. A second, invisible sun crosses the night sky. A few people perceive its radiance, and magic is the craft of catching and refracting it. The academy is an observatory-university on a mountain.

Protagonist. A 35-year-old lighthouse keeper.

Mechanism. Refraction of night-light through lenses and the eye. The cost is the gradual loss of ordinary sight.

Emotional foundation. Vision, faith, what we choose not to see.

Conflict / mystery. The second sun is dimming. *Truth:* it is an artefact, built.

Seven-book potential. Moderate. "The sun is artificial" is a familiar reveal in SF-fantasy.

Concept E — THE WEIR COLLEGIUM

Premise. An invisible current, the Flux, flows through the land like water. Mages are its hydraulic engineers, building weirs, locks and sluices. Whoever controls the great weirs controls the land.

Protagonist. A 31-year-old canal lock-keeper.

Mechanism. Channelling and damming the Flux. The cost: dammed Flux pools in the engineer's body.

Emotional foundation. Control and flow, infrastructure and care.

Conflict / mystery. The upstream source is being diverted.

Seven-book potential. Moderate. It is mechanically elegant but emotionally cooler, and the "flowing energy" magic is a well-worn shape.

Evaluation matrix (1–10)

Criterion	A Halcyon	B Echo	C Postal	D Lamp	E Weir
Originality	8	8	9	6	6

Criterion	A Halcyon	B Echo	C Postal	D Lamp	E Weir
Emotional depth	10	8	7	7	6
Sense of wonder	9	8	7	8	6
Mystery potential	10	8	8	6	6
Character potential	9	7	7	6	7
Narrative sustainability (7 bks)	10	6	6	5	6
Distinctiveness	8	8	9	6	6
Academy appeal	10	8	7	8	6
Intellectual richness	9	8	8	7	8
Commercial readability	9	7	7	8	7
Total	92	76	75	67	64

Selection: Concept A, THE HALCYON

Why it wins. It does not win on having the most lore. Its mechanism *is* its theme. Keep / Read / Return maps exactly onto grief, history and restitution. The protagonist's private wound (keeping her brother) mirrors the civilisation's founding crime (keeping the sea), so every personal choice carries saga weight and every saga revelation lands as personal. The academy is irreplaceable: a university literally dug into the evidence of the crime.

Weaknesses identified and refinements made: 1. *"Stasis/preservation" is broad and easily static.* ❑ Add the arrears law. Keeping is never free and never truly still. Pressure builds, and pressure produces events: weeping, quickenings, ruptures. Stillness becomes a source of plot. 2. *A salt-white world risks visual monotony.* ❑ Vary the palette: brine pools tinted red and green by halophile algae (real-world grounded); kept-light lanterns of amber daylight; black lattice-glass; the red of forbidden human salt; the blue of deep ice-salt. 3. *Overlap with* The Salt Oracle *(mentor dies investigation save one or save the college).* ❑ - The dead Reader is *not* Hester's mentor. She has known him eleven days. - The death is not a murder plot but a concealed manslaughter. - The dilemma's resolution *rejects* the binary through an insight: venting. - The central question is economic and historical, not a ghost/oracle question. 4. *Overlap with "turned to*

salt" imagery (Lot's wife; *The Salt King*). ❡ Our people are never *turned into* salt. They are *kept within* a casing of it, alive and paused, and can be returned. The casing is clear, like glass, not a pillar. *5. Risk of a grim, joyless tone.* ❡ Hester's dry wit; Teo's warmth; the daily pleasures of the academy (the Lantern Hour, salt-sugar pastries, the Ninth-Fathom choir); the comedy of exam culture. 6. *Risk that the saga truth is guessable early.* ❡ Book One shows only that the deep salt is pressured and that something kept in it is alive (a creature). The *people* in the moment are not revealed until Book Four. The founders' guilt comes in Book Five.

Originality Audit

This audit separates broad genre conventions (free for anyone: academies, mentors, exams, mysteries, magic with costs) from distinctive expression (specific combinations, institutions, artefacts, terminology and plot machinery that identify a particular franchise). Any element that drifted toward the second category was replaced.

A. Harry Potter–adjacent risks, and the decisions taken

Familiar element	Risk	Decision
Students sorted into houses that compete for points	Highly distinctive HP machinery	Removed. No houses. Students join a *Bench*, a small research group under one Reader, chosen by mutual consent and examined publicly. Belonging is earned, not assigned.
Child protagonist entering at 11; boarding school	Core HP/YA shape	Protagonist is 33, an employed adult with a dependent and a debt. Classmates range from 22 to 40s. Most lodge in a working dormitory; some commute; one is a widowed parent.
Orphan with a hidden heritage or destiny	HP, plus a broad cliché	Rejected. Hester's parents are a brine-boiler (alive, estranged) and a dead laundress. Her talent is a common aptitude made exceptional by 20 years of customs work. Her importance comes from choices and expertise.
Wands, spells, incantations	HP signature	No wands, no words. Magic is a bodily discipline (the *hold*),

Familiar element	Risk	Decision
		plus a material (stillsalt), plus a medium (brine).
Dark lord and followers	HP signature; generic	No dark lord. Antagonism is structural: the Halcyon itself, the Exchequer, a founding crime. Book One's antagonist is a protective, loved Warden whose reasoning is sound and whose choice is wrong.
Headmaster as wise protector	HP signature	The Chancellor is a political survivor who keeps the founding secret. She is not a guardian figure.
Secret chamber beneath the school	Broad convention, but HP has a famous one	Ours is not a hidden room with a monster. The *Hush* is the school's lowest layer, where the evidence of the crime is under pressure. It is known, sealed and administered, and its danger is physics, not a creature.
Sports tournament / house cup	HP	No sport. The academy's public spectacle is the Midwinter Assay, an open examination watched by the city. There is also Lantern Night, a civic festival of released summer light.
Magical prison, ministry	HP institutions	Our institutions are economic: the Charter of the Grain (a licensing monopoly), the Salt Exchequer, the Delvers' Guild.

B. Other franchise and recent-novel risks

Source	Risk	Decision
The Name of the Wind (Rothfuss): a university, sympathy magic, "the Archives", a poor gifted student, tuition stress	Poor-scholar-at-university plus sympathetic links	Our "still runs to quick" law could read as sympathy. Changed: stillness travels only through physically continuous live brine, like heat through metal. There are no symbolic links and no "binding" words. The library is not a sealed archive with a mythic door; the Brinestacks are a working library of salt tablets. The money anxiety is a care fee, not tuition.
Babel (Kuang): an academy whose magic powers an empire's economy	Institution-as-extraction	The economic critique is a broad tradition (dark academia's "it is the house"). Ours differs in mechanism (preservation, not translation), in history (the extracted resource is a *people's held moment*), and in resolution (restoration, not revolution). We avoid colonial-translation imagery and silver bars.
The Salt Oracle (Wilson, 2025): a mentor's death; investigation; save the one or save the college	Structural overlap	The dead man has known Hester 16 days; he is a sponsor, not a mentor. He is not dead: he is kept, which reverses the "dead mentor" shape. The dilemma is dissolved by an insight (venting), not decided.
The Salt King (Pulley, 2026); Lot's wife	"Turned to salt"	No one is transformed into salt. Keepings are clear casings around a living, paused person, and they can be returned.
	Tidal mystique	

Source	Risk	Decision
Piranesi (Clarke): a house of tides		No tidal architecture; our sea is absent. Its *sounds* survive in the salt as a "roar", which is a different device.
The Memory Police (Ogawa): things vanish	Disappearance	Nothing vanishes in our world; things are *held*.
Mistborn (Sanderson): metals as magic resource; an oppressive establishment	Mineral magic	Ours is a single material with three operations and a cost paid in the worker's own body-time. The establishment is an academy, not a god-emperor. We do not use "burning" or ingestion.
Generic "academy built on a dead god" (various)	Overused	The academy is built in a salt dome on a seabed. The "secret beneath" is a crime of statecraft, not divinity.

C. Terminology check

Coined or repurposed terms: Halcyon (the academy), stillsalt/grain, the hold, Keep/Read/Return, arrears, quickening, the Stay, the Stay Choir, the Hush, Fathoms (as levels), Bench, Reader's Privilege, Assay, Lantern Hour, Lantern Night, kept light, the Roar, the Settle, lag, the Cold House, the Cistern, Tiders / the Order of the Returning Tide, the Ebb, the White, the Rim, landships, sols and flecks, the Seal.

Common-word checks: - "Halcyon" is common English (and Greek myth). Its use here as an academy name and myth anchor is not tied to any known franchise. - "Reader" as a faculty rank exists at real universities; that is appropriate. - No term duplicates a distinctive coinage from a major fantasy franchise, as far as reasonable checking allows.

D. Plot-structure check

[A]The academy murder mystery is a broad convention. We transform it: the "victim" is alive, the "murderer" kept rather than killed, and the motive is civic protection.

[A]Saga escalation follows our own logic, not the "returning villain, stronger each year" pattern. City mystery $_{q}$ institutional politics $_{q}$ expedition $_{q}$ first contact $_{q}$ civil war $_{q}$ engineering catastrophe $_{q}$ restitution.

E. Voice

The narrative voice is developed independently (see STYLE_GUIDE.md): close-third, dry and exact, built on the protagonist's trade vocabulary of weights, tastes and grades. It does not imitate any living author's distinctive style.

Residual risk

The broad pleasures of the genre (arrival at a wondrous school, first lessons, friendships, an exam, a hidden danger below) are kept deliberately. They are genre conventions, and the brief explicitly asks for that emotional appeal.

Research Notes — Craft, Conventions, Production

Purpose: record what was learned, from where, and how it changes the project. Researched principles are marked [R]; my own artistic choices drawn from them are marked [A].

Research was kept focused and short on purpose. Most craft principles below are long established in published craft writing. Web sources consulted this session are listed at the end.

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1. Magical-academy and dark-academia fiction

[R] What the genre runs on. Criticism of the recent academic-fantasy boom (Post45's dark academia cluster; Nguyen, *Nostalgia in Dark Academia*, 2022; Book Riot's survey of dark academia tropes) names the same core things: a *longing to be transformed* by study; a closed community; knowledge as obsession; murder or death; class division the hero has to cross; an institution that seduces and corrupts. *The Secret History* is the usual origin point named for the adult strand.

[R] The most cited weakness. Reactor's essay "Beyond Dark Academia" argues that magic-school stories drift toward *external monsters* and skip the reasons the school itself is frightening. Its summary: "the murderer isn't just calling from inside the house — it is the house." The institution is the horror.

[R] Overused shapes to avoid: the sorting ceremony; houses and points; an orphan with a secret destiny; a dark lord's return; a teenage cohort; a headmaster who is a guardian figure; Eurocentric pastoral nostalgia as the default backdrop.

[R] Recent overlap risks found while checking originality: - Lorraine Wilson, *The Salt Oracle* (2025): a floating college; a researcher's mentor dies; she invest-

igates a possible murder; the choice is between saving one being and saving the college. - Natasha Pulley, *The Salt King* (2026): a priest is healed and then turned to salt; a Dead Sea dig. Neither shares our mechanism, world or cast. But the *structure* "mentor dies $_{q}$ protagonist investigates $_{q}$ save the one or save the college" and the image "a person turned to salt" are close enough that we must design away from them (see ORIGINALITY_AUDIT.md).

[A] How this shapes us: - The academy *is* the source of the danger. It works as regulator, monopoly and economic engine. Its founding act is the saga's buried crime. That makes "it is the house" structural, not decorative. - The students are adults with debts, children, jobs and pasts. The protagonist is 33. - There are no houses and no sorting. Students attach to a *Bench*, a working research group under one Reader, and status is earned at the Assay, a public exam. - The class crossing is concrete. Hester comes from the brine-boiling district and works for the customs house. She enters through a sponsor's privilege, not through a bloodline.

2. Magic-system design

[R] Sanderson's Second Law (brandonsanderson.com; Coppermind summary): limitations, costs and weaknesses are more interesting than powers. Depth beats breadth: a few powers, considered fully. [R] Sanderson's First Law: an author's ability to solve conflict with magic is directly proportional to how well the reader understands that magic.

[A] Application: the system has three operations (Keep, Read, Return) and one universal cost (arrears, plus the worker's own lent stillness). Every climax solution must use a principle the reader has already seen. The Book One climax depends on "venting," a technique built only from principles taught in Chapters 6–14.

3. Mystery construction

[R] Fair play (Knox's Decalogue, 1929; Van Dine's Twenty Rules; CrimeReads's "A Magician's Contract"): the reader gets the same clues as the detective; no su-

pernatural solution the reader could not anticipate; no clue hoarding. A modern test: careful readers *could* solve it even if most do not. [R] The supernatural caveat matters for fantasy. Magic is allowed only once its rules are on the page.

[A] Application: - Every load-bearing clue in Book One appears at least once before the reveal, ideally twice, in different registers (one physical, one in dialogue). - The culprit appears early, often, sympathetically, and has a visible motive that the reader misreads as virtue. - Red herrings are innocent of the crime but guilty of something smaller, so suspecting them stays rational. - Hester narrates in close third person. We never hide what she knows. Where she withholds a conclusion from herself, the narrative shows it as avoidance.

4. Character psychology and reader attachment

[R] Long-established craft consensus: readers attach to *competence plus vulnerability plus desire*. A character is defined by choices under pressure, and the gap between what a character wants and what they need drives the arc (the want/need distinction). Flaws should be rooted in virtues pushed too far.

[A] Application: - Hester's *want* is to keep her brother alive, unchanged. Her *need* is to learn that keeping is not the same as loving. - Her virtue is fidelity. Her flaw is the same fidelity turned into control. - The theme lives at three scales at once: personal (her brother), institutional (the Halcyon), civilisational (the sea).

5. Pacing and long-form architecture

[R] Structure: a four-movement structure (setup / complication / reversal / resolution) is common in commercial fiction. A midpoint reversal, a dark moment around 75%, and a climax built from earlier setups are standard. [R] Series craft: each book needs its own question answered. Saga questions advance but are not resolved. A cliffhanger does not replace resolution.

[A] Application: - Book One's question, "Why are the keepings weeping, and who killed Corvin Aske?", is fully answered. - The saga question, "What is the Hollow Sea?", is advanced by one undeniable fact: something in the salt is alive.

6. Prose and dialogue

[R] Standard editorial guidance: specific nouns over adjectives. Subtext in dialogue. Vary sentence length. Cut throat-clearing. Prefer action-beat attributions sparingly and "said" otherwise. Avoid repeated physical-tic emotion ("her heart hammered").

[A] Banned-phrase list for this project, covering generic generated-fiction tics. It is kept in STYLE_GUIDE.md.

7. Book production and EPUB accessibility

[R] W3C EPUB Accessibility 1.1: - EPUB content should meet WCAG 2.x AA. - Accessibility metadata (`schema:accessMode`, `accessibilityFeature`, `accessibilityHazard`, `accessibilitySummary`) is required for discoverability. - Meaningful images need descriptive alt text. Decorative images take `alt=""`. - Use a logical reading order, and set language metadata.

[R] Navigation and validation (DAISY Knowledge Base; IDPF a11y guidelines): - The nav document must contain `epub:type="toc"`. - `landmarks` are recommended. - Use semantic `epub:type`. - EPUBCheck validates spec conformance. Ace by DAISY checks accessibility but cannot judge whether alt text is good.

[A] Application: - We build EPUB 3 by hand (XHTML + OPF + nav + NCX for older readers), with full a11y metadata. - We validate with EPUBCheck 5.x (pip `epubcheck` bundles it). - PDF: 6×9 in via WeasyPrint with EB Garamond, plus a mobile PDF.

Sources consulted (this session)

[A] W3C, EPUB Accessibility 1.1 — https://www.w3.org/TR/epub-a11y

[A] IDPF EPUB 3 Accessibility Guidelines — https://idpf.github.io/a11y-guidelines/content/wcag-aria.html

[A] DAISY Knowledge Base — https://kb.daisy.org/publishing/docs/topics.html

[A]BookNet Canada, EPUB accessibility conformance overview — https://booknetcanada.ca/blog/2019/3/15/act-in-3-acts-an-overview-of-epub-accessibility-conformance-testing

[A]Sanderson's Laws of Magic (Coppermind) — https://coppermind.net/wiki/Sanderson%27s_Laws_of_Magic

[A]Brandon Sanderson, "Sanderson's Second Law" — https://brandonsanderson.com/sandersons-second-law/

[A]Post45, Dark Academia cluster introduction — https://post45.org/2022/03/introduction-3/

[A]Book Riot, Themes, Tropes, and Types of Dark Academia — https://bookriot.com/dark-academia-tropes-and-themes/

[A]Reactor, "Beyond Dark Academia: The Real Horror in Magic School Is Systemic Inequality" — https://reactormag.com/beyond-dark-academia-the-real-horror-in-magic-school-is-systemic-inequality/

[A]Nguyen, "Nostalgia in Dark Academia" (2022) — https://strathprints.strath.ac.uk/84509/1/Nguyen_EWCP_2022_Nostalgia_in_dark_academia.pdf

[A]CrimeReads, "A Magician's Contract Between Reader and Writer" — https://crimereads.com/a-magicians-contract-between-reader-and-writer-rules-for-delivering-a-whodunit/

[A]No Film School, Knox's Ten Commandments — https://nofilmschool.com/ronald-knox-detective-fiction-commandments

[A]Overlap checks: *The Salt Oracle* (Simon & Schuster UK listing) — https://www.simonandschuster.co.uk/books/The-Salt-Oracle/Lorraine-Wilson/9781837865741 ; *The Salt King* and other salt-titled fantasy (search summaries).

No source text was copied into the project. These sources informed principles only.

STYLE GUIDE — *What the Salt Keeps*

Narrative conventions (locked)

[A]POV: close third, Hester Vail only. Past tense. We never enter another head.

[A]Chapter heading in source: `# Chapter N` then `## Title`, then an epigraph block, then the text.

[A]Epigraph: a markdown blockquote (`> ...`) of 1–4 lines, plus an attribution line `> — *Source*`. Keep it short, in-world and dryly informative. It may be funny.

[A]Scene breaks: a line containing only `* * *`.

[A]Dialogue: double quotes. "Said" by default. Action beats sparingly. No adverb-laden tags.

[A]Numbers: spell out in dialogue and narration up to one hundred, except dates ("6 Russet"), fathom numbers ("the Fifth Fathom"), casing numbers ("casing two hundred and eleven" in speech, "211" on a label), and money in figures when written ("6 sols") but words in speech.

[A]Capitalisation: the Halcyon; the White; the Hollow Sea; the Rim; the Ebb; the Fifth Fathom; the Hush; the Stay Choir / the Choir; a stay / the Stays (as a place); the Stair; the Line; the Lantern; the Lantern Hour; Lantern Night; the Assay; the Long Table; the Brinestacks; the Quiet Rooms; the Cold House; the Cistern; the Settle; the Roar; the Charter; Reader, Warden, Chancellor, Proctor (as titles); aspirant (lower case); grain, stillsalt, live brine, keeping, casing, the hold, the release, lag, arrears, quickening (lower case).

[A]Spelling: British-inflected spelling (colour, grey, centre, practise as a verb). Use "towards" or "toward" consistently: toward.

[A]Time: bells. First bell is dawn (about 6); the Halcyon rings twelve bells from dawn; "the tenth bell" is evening (about 9 p.m.).

The voice

[A]Dry, exact, observant. Hester notices weights, textures, prices, lies and the tare of things (the weight of the container versus its contents).

[A]Humour comes from understatement and from characters' collisions, never from narratorial winking.

[A]Sensory anchor: taste and weight first (Hester's sense), then cold, sound, light.

[A]Wonder is delivered by precision, not adjectives. Don't call things "breathtaking"; say exactly what they did.

[A]Emotion is shown through behaviour and the body. When Hester feels something large, she usually does something small: counts coins, straightens a spoon, tastes the air.

[A]Metaphor discipline: prefer metaphors from Hester's world (assay, scales, brine-boiling, customs ledgers, laundry, Lowside streets). Never use the same metaphor twice in a chapter. No more than one striking simile per paragraph.

[A]Sentences: vary them hard. Short declaratives for impact. Longer periodic sentences for wonder. Fragments are allowed and earned.

Character voice crib

[A]Hester: short. Lowside turns sparingly ("I'll not," "wants doing," "ta"). Never says "I feel."

[A]Teo: warm, digressive, self-mocking; food; scripture with irony; long sentences that land softly.

[A]Saskia: clipped, ironic, numbers and money; Quellish bluntness; tender only with Pip.

[A]Lucan: formal, Latinate, ironic, precise; when he's sincere, his sentences get shorter.

[A]Sorle: baroque periods with a sting at the end; calls her "Miss Vail"; insults as affection.

[A]Orsolya: Lowside warmth; "chick"; practical; the steel shows in plain short sentences.

[A]Aske: delighted, fast, digressive; "Oh, that's *wrong*."

[A]Aldous: monosyllables, proverbs, then a sudden long true sentence.

[A]Agathe: gentle, Tider phrases ("tide willing"), practical.

[A]Gage: procedural, clipped, soldier's diction.

[A]Crisp: terse, technical.

[A]Bassano: florid, gossipy, kind.

[A]Callow: extremely slow, few words, often with ellipses of time ("He took the length of a held breath to answer").

Banned / restricted phrases (generic generated-fiction tics)

Never use: - "a testament to" - "the weight of [abstract]" (literal weight is fine and encouraged) - "something shifted" / "the air shifted" - "let out a breath she didn't know she'd been holding" (doubly banned in a world where holding is magic) - "a dance of", "tapestry", "symphony of" - "palpable" - "electric" (for tension) - "her heart hammered/pounded" (max once in the whole book) - "eyes widened" (max 3 in the book) - "a beat of silence" / "a heartbeat later" - "the silence stretched" - "little did she know" - "in that moment" - "it was as if time stood still" (ironic in this book; banned) - "she couldn't help but" - "ministrations" - "the ghost of a smile" - "barely above a whisper" - "a mixture of X and Y" - "deafening silence" - "orbs" - "unspoken understanding" - "Somewhere, a dog barked." - "Her breath hitched." - "a wave of [emotion] washed over"

Restricted: - "suddenly" (rare) - "very" (rare) - "began to" / "started to" (cut where possible) - rhetorical-question strings in narration (max 2 in a row) - one-line paragraph chapter endings (allowed at most every third chapter)

Exposition rules

[A]No lore paragraph longer than about 120 words without a character doing or wanting something.

[A]Teach magic through use, mistakes and argument. Lectures are allowed (Sorle, Crisp) if they are *dramatic*, with someone humiliated, defied or surprised.

[A]Do not repeat a fact the reader has already been given, unless a character is *using* it.

Chapter endings

Vary them: an image; a line of dialogue; an action; a quiet thought; a turn. Do not end every chapter on a cliffhanger. Do not end chapters with summary-sentiment ("And she knew nothing would ever be the same").

Content

Adult: grief, death, class, money, sex alluded to but not depicted, swearing in moderation (Lowside "tide take it," "salt and sorrow," real swearing sparingly: "bloody," "hell," occasional "shit").

Visual Style Guide — The Halcyon Cycle

Principles

Wonder through restraint. These are scholarly, atmospheric and symbolic images, not busy "epic fantasy" painting. Every image is original vector work generated in code (`build/make_*.py`). No AI image generation was used, because no such tool was available in this environment.

Palette

Role	Colour	Hex
Night sky / deep	ink indigo	#0b1626 $_{q}$ #1d3550
Salt	bone white	#f4f6f7 / #ffffff
Held sea	glacier blue	#7d9bb3 $_{q}$ #2f4b66
Kept light	lantern amber	#ffd27a / #f4b860
Paper (maps)	parchment	#f7f3ea
Ink (maps)	slate	#2a3440
Pinkwater accent	rose	#e9b7b0

Typography

- [A]EB Garamond (SIL OFL) for all display and body text.
- [A]Titles are set in letterspaced capitals (tracking ≈ 0.1 em).
- [A]The series line is small caps with wide spacing. Italics are kept for subtitles and captions.

Recurring motifs

[A]The Lantern: a thin tower with an amber head. It stands for knowledge, the institution and watchfulness.

[A]The cross-section: the world shown cut open, with the surface above and the held depths below. This is the series' signature composition.

[A]The crystal cube: a keeping. Its contents hint at the secret of each book.

[A]The halcyon ornament: a kingfisher-like bird on a single straight line (a wave stilled). It serves as the chapter ornament and series mark.

Seven-book cover system

All seven covers share one structure: - the series line at top; - the title in tracked capitals; - a dark upper field with a single central motif; - a pale "salt" lower field; - the author line at the foot.

Each book has its own hue and motif:

Book	Hue	Motif	Spoiler-safe?
1 What the Salt Keeps	indigo/ice	Lantern, Fathoms, kept gull (in the cube)	The gull is a symbol to a new reader
2 The Lantern Tithe	amber/umber	floating kept-light lanterns	yes
3 A Map of Still Water	deep blue	a landship sail on the White	yes (no city shown)
4 The Drowned Choir	violet	concentric sound rings	yes (abstract)
5 The Red Grain	crimson	red crystals	yes
6 The Ebb Reversed	teal	rising water lines	title-level only
7 When the Sea Remembers	dusk blue/sand	birds over open water	title-level only

The covers for Books 2–7 are provisional. They are labelled so on the art and are not final commercial art.

Interior art

[A] `ornament.svg/png`: the chapter-opening ornament (decorative, `alt=""`).

[A] `map_rim.svg/png`: the world map (rotated version for 6×9 print).

[A] `halcyon_section.svg/png`: a cross-section of the academy. It deliberately omits the Cistern and the Old Tap to avoid spoilers.